



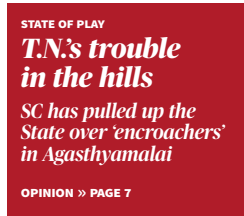
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IN BRIEF

Operation Toofan a social movement, says Chennithala

NEW DELHI
Operation Toofan, Kerala's anti-drug drive, is not just a policing exercise but also a social movement, State Home Minister Ramesh Chennithala said. The police have lodged 10,213 cases and arrested 9,941 people within 76 days of its launch, he said. » Page 4

Delhi HC questions terms to avail of Lakshmi Yojana aid

NEW DELHI
The Delhi High Court on Wednesday questioned the government's decision to require an endorsement from the local MP or MLA for women seeking benefits under the Lakshmi Yojana. » Page 3



GS-II
BY DR. SATYK SHAN
Starts: 23rd August, 2026
9540886666
B-29, 2nd Floor, DDA, New Delhi

NTA reforms should have meaningful continuity: SC

Reforms in the agency must be institutionalised and not a knee-jerk reaction to a catastrophe, says the top court; it questions the government hopping from one panel to other in search of solutions

Krishnadas Rajagopal
NEW DELHI

The Supreme Court on Wednesday emphasised the need for institutionalising reforms within the National Testing Agency (NTA) while indicating that the government must not hop from one committee to the next in search of solutions. The court made it clear that the constitution of the new Nandan Nilekani task force must not be seen as a move to discard "lock, stock, and barrel" an earlier panel headed by a former Indian Space Research Organisation (ISRO) chief.

The testing agency has been under the Supreme Court's scanner since the National Eligibility-cum-Entrance Test-Undergrad-

Structural solutions

The top court is hearing petitions alleging 'recurring, systemic, and catastrophic failure' in the NTA ecosystem

■ A seven-member committee formed in 2024 under ISRO's former Chairman K. Radhakrishnan had recommended a series of structural reforms in the NEET system

■ The Centre has also constituted a 'task force' chaired by Infosys co-founder Nandan Nilekani to usher in 'new technological reforms' in the NTA



It should not be that a committee gives recommendations, then a new committee is formed which removes the old one, lock, stock and barrel
JUSTICE P.S. NARASIMHA
SC judge

uate (NEET-UG) 2026 paper leaks. The Centre has constituted the "task force" chaired by Mr. Nilekani, Infosys co-founder, to usher in new technological reforms which would make the conduct of public exams under the NTA leak-proof. But a Bench headed

by Justice P.S. Narasimha persisted to question the Centre on what it has done so far to implement the recommendations of an earlier committee headed by former ISRO Chairperson K. Radhakrishnan to improve the NTA's exam processes.

The court was hearing petitions from the Federation of All India Medical Association and United Doctors Front highlighting that 2026 paper leak was part of a "recurring, systemic, and catastrophic failure" of the NTA in conducting the NEET-UG exam. "It should not be that a committee gives recommendations, then a new committee is formed which removes the old one, lock, stock and barrel," Justice Narasimha said.

The reforms must be vibrant, institutionalised, and carried on within the NTA by successive officers. They should not be a knee-jerk reaction after a catastrophe, he said.

CONTINUED ON
» PAGE 10

Kolkata blaze kills 9; at least 5 victims from Bangladesh

Senjuti Sengupta
Shrabana Chatterjee
KOLKATA

At least nine people, a child among them, were killed after a fire broke out in the early hours of Wednesday at a hotel in the Mirza Ghalib Street area of Kolkata in West Bengal. Five of the deceased were Bangladeshi nationals, one from Bihar and one from West Bengal, and two were yet to be identified. Around 60 people were rescued from the building.

The police said the fire started around 2 a.m. inside Sikha Inn, located on the second floor of Florence Mansion, a five-storey building that has several guesthouses and inns, largely frequented by Bangladeshi nationals visiting Kolkata. The narrow metal staircase made it difficult for the occupants to escape, the police said.

"I was on the third floor and suddenly saw a lot of smoke coming into the



Deadly fire: Police personnel near the building in Kolkata where a fire broke out on Wednesday. PTI

room. The entire floor was enveloped in smoke and I jumped out of the window to escape the fire," said Ijaz Ahmed, one of the survivors. Local people and survivors said the building did not have any firefighting equipment.

A five-member special investigation team, led by the Deputy Commissioner of the Detective Department of Kolkata Police, has been set up to probe the incident. The police have registered a first information

report (FIR), said Kunal Agarwal, Additional Commissioner of Kolkata Police (Crime). The FIR has been filed under several sections of the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita, including culpable homicide not amounting to murder and negligence, and under Sections of the West Bengal Fire Services Act. The hotel's owner, Bireswar Mitra, is absconding, said the police.

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72 in Top 100 Ranks

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Daman Night Market

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Daman Night Market

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Publication of draft electoral roll deferred to Aug. 31: EC

Suruchi Kumari
NEW DELHI

The Election Commission of India (EC) on Wednesday issued an order deferring the publication of the draft electoral roll for Delhi as part of the special intensive revision (SIR) to August 31 from August 24, following a request from Delhi Chief Electoral Officer Ashok Kumar for more time to complete the rationalisation of polling stations to a limit of 1,200 voters per booth, an official said.

The final roll will now be published on November 4. The filing of claims and objections will be open from August 31 to September 30, while the notice and disposal phase will continue until October 29, according to the EC order.

A senior election official said the rationalisation process, which involves identifying polling stations with more than 1,200 voters from the existing 1,500 and shifting electors to another or a new polling station, was scheduled to be completed along with the door-to-door enumeration phase on August 17 but is still under way.

Across the 13 districts, 5,480 of the 13,033 polling stations were found to have more than 1,200 electors, according to data accessed by *The Hindu*.

As of Monday, the initial deadline for rationalisation, nearly 270 polling stations were still pending across 15 constituencies, including Sangam Vihar, Dwarka, Matiala, Palam, Krishna Nagar, Laxmi Nagar and Karawal Nagar.

Jain and 5 others sent to two weeks' judicial custody in tender case

Court grants ACB two-day police custody of Ankit Srivastava; AAP leader's counsel questions the circumstances leading to his arrest a day earlier

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

A Delhi court on Wednesday remanded former Water Minister and senior AAP leader Satyendar Jain, former Delhi Jal Board (DJB) CEO Udit Prakash Rai and three others in 14-day judicial custody in connection with an alleged corruption case linked to the award of tenders for sewage treatment plant (STP) projects.

Special Judge Dig Vinay Singh granted the Delhi Anti Corruption Branch (ACB) two days' police custody of Ankit Srivastava, a former contractual consultant with the DJB. The court also sought the ACB's response to a bail application filed by Mr. Jain through his counsel during the day. On Tuesday, the ACB arrested Mr. Jain, Mr. Rai, Mr. Srivastava, Nagen-dra Yadav, Raja Kumar Kurra, and Pankaj Verma.

During Wednesday's hearing, Mr. Jain's counsel questioned the circumstances leading to his arrest, pointing out that the FIR had been registered on May 10, 2024. The lawyer submitted that Mr. Jain was first called for questioning on August 5 this year and was contacted again by phone on Tuesday before being arrested.

The counsel argued that the agency had not placed any material on record



AAP leader Satyendar Jain being produced before the court in New Delhi on Wednesday. P11

warranting Mr. Jain's arrest. Mr. Rai's lawyer also challenged the arrest, drawing the court's attention to the fact that the former DJB CEO is currently serving as Secretary in the Mizoram government.

The arrests were made in connection with a case registered following a complaint by the Directorate of Vigilance regarding alleged irregularities in and manipulation of the tendering process for the augmentation and upgradation of STPs in the Capital.

AAP, BJP trade barbs

The arrests triggered a fresh political confrontation between AAP and the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) on Wednesday, with leaders of the two parties trading allegations.

"Union Home Minister Amit Shah must explain why he pressured the investigating agency to get Satyendar Jain arrested. An Anti Corruption Branch of

ficer said that until the morning, the ACB had no plan to arrest Satyendar Jain," AAP national convenor Arvind Kejriwal said in a post on X.

Senior AAP leader and Rajya Sabha MP Sanjay Singh said Mr. Jain, who is also the party's co-in-charge of Punjab, was arrested "by the BJP out of frustration" as they are facing a "crushing defeat" in the State Assembly election next year.

Hitting back, Delhi BJP president Harsh Malhotra said that AAP was a "politically desperate party completely immersed in corruption" and with investigations and arrests taking place, it was playing the "victim card". "For 10 years, the accounts of the DJB were not audited, and an alleged scam of nearly ₹60,000 crore took place. The day the complete report comes out, Arvind Kejriwal himself may possibly end up in jail," he said.

HC questions govt. on need for MP/MLA endorsement to avail Lakshmi Yojana aid

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

The Delhi High Court on Wednesday questioned the government's decision to require an endorsement from the local MP or MLA for women seeking benefits under the 'Delhi Lakshmi Yojana', which provides financial assistance of ₹2,500 a month.

A Bench of Chief Justice D.K. Upadhyaya and Justice Tejas Karia said such an endorsement could not be justified when eligibility could be verified through other documents. The court asked the government to seek instructions on the issue and listed the matter for August 24.

The plea argued that the endorsement clause gave MPs and MLAs unbridled discretion over welfare benefits

"Seek instructions. We can't approve of it," the Bench told the government counsel. The proceedings arose from a public interest litigation (PIL) filed by former Congress councillor Abhishek Dutt and sitting councillor Vedpal Sheetal Chaudhary.

The Bench noted that the requirement of a legislator's endorsement did not find mention in the scheme, which specifies

detailed eligibility conditions for beneficiaries. "Why are you asking them to approach the MLA or the MP?" the court said.

"We are of a prima facie view that in assessing as to whether a woman fulfils the criteria, various documents can be asked for. It is possible that a woman may or may not get the endorsement of the MP/MLA of her constituency. In any case, the scheme does not mention any requirement of an endorsement letter," the court observed.

The petitioners argued that making a recommendation or endorsement from the local MP or MLA mandatory gave political representatives "unbridled

discretion" and effectively turned a welfare entitlement into an instrument of political patronage.

According to the PIL, the scheme came into operation on August 1, when the Delhi government launched an online registration portal. The petitioners said the portal made submission of a recommendation or endorsement letter from the concerned MP or MLA a compulsory requirement for registration.

The plea cited the lack of redressal if an MP/MLA refused endorsement and sought transparent, objective aid-disbursal guidelines free from political interference.

Jashn-e-Adab to mark 15 years with four-day literary, cultural festival

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

Jashn-e-Adab Sahityotsava will mark its 15th foundation day with a four-day literary and cultural festival in Delhi from August 21 to 24, featuring poetry, music, dance and performing arts at the India International Centre and India Habitat Centre.

Founder Kunwar Ranjeet Chauhan said, "We founded the organisation in 2012 to provide a platform with multiple stages where Indian languages, art and culture could be brought together and promoted. Over the years, the festival has grown. So far, we have taken it to 15 States."

On August 21, the festival will feature 'Yuva Bahaar', Mohan Veena and Rajasthani folk music.

August 22 will feature dangstooi, classical dance and qawwali. August 23 will have Sufi music, conversations and ghazals. On August 24, the festival will feature *Vande Mataram* and Hindustani classical music.

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Gupta, L-G flag off 56 ladies' special buses, including 26 on Delhi University routes

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

Lieutenant-Governor (L-G) Taranjit Singh Sandhu and Chief Minister Rekha Gupta on Wednesday flagged off 56 ladies' special buses, including 26 buses on Delhi University (DU) routes, from the Delhi University Sports Complex. They also flagged off 200 new electric buses, launched the Delhi-Karnal e-bus service and inaugurated an electric vehicle (EV) charging station at Rajghat Depot-1.

Ms. Gupta said the 56 women-only buses include 30 on 15 high-demand routes and 26 on 13 DU-



L-G Taranjit Singh Sandhu and CM Rekha Gupta flagging off the new buses at Delhi University Sports Complex. SUSHI KUMAR VERMA

specific routes. They will operate during morning and evening peak hours, with women police personnel, Home Guards and female staff deployed on board. The buses will cover

around DU colleges, she added.

Ms. Gupta also said that the ladies' special bus service was an important step towards ensuring safe, dignified and convenient travel for women and female

students.

"The initiative would provide students with safe and comfortable transport between their colleges and major residential areas," she added.

The addition of 200 e-buses has taken the electric fleet beyond 5,000 and the overall Delhi Transport Corporation (DTC) fleet to 6,800, the Chief Minister said. The new fleet comprises 88 12-metre buses and 112 nine-metre DEVI buses. The DTC also launched five air-conditioned buses between Kashmir Gate and Karnal which would make 10 trips daily in each direction.

CNG cylinder blast at filling station near Tikri Kalan kills three

Lavpreet Kaur
NEW DELHI

Three persons were killed and three others injured after a CNG cylinder installed in a truck exploded at a filling station near Tikri Kalan metro station in west Delhi on Wednesday, the police said.

The deceased were identified as Manish, 25, Sunny, 32, and Brahmi, 34, all employees of the CNG filling station. Of the three injured, Surjeet, 32, and Sanjay, 37, were shifted to a Mundka hospital, where they were undergoing treatment; Vinip sustained minor injuries.

According to the police, six persons were standing near the truck when the explosion occurred

around 3.20 p.m. Seven fire tenders were rushed to the spot following a distress call, though no fire-fighting was required.

Blast impact

Speaking to *The Hindu*, DCP (Outer) Vikram Singh said that the truck had multiple CNG cylinders fitted underneath it and the blast occurred while gas was being filled into one of them. "Manish, a station employee who was filling the gas, bore the brunt of the blast and died on the spot. Two other men who were in the vicinity of the truck also sustained fatal injuries," he said.

The explosion damaged another truck, a van, a scooter and equipment at the filling station.

Govt. orders new postings for 111 DSS cadre officers

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

The government has issued orders for the promotion and new postings of 111 Delhi Subordinate Services (DSS) cadre officers with the aim of strengthening the administrative set-up, the CMO stated in a release on Wednesday.

"The promotions reflect the Delhi government's commitment to advancing the careers of its employees and encouraging their spirit of service. The government has ensured that officers receive due recognition and promotion. The decision is an important step towards addressing the long-standing stagnation in the DSS cadre," Chief Minister Rekha Gupta said.

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States

IN BRIEF

Jharkhand BJP leaders meet
Amit Shah in New Delhi

A delegation of the Jharkhand Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP), led by its State chief Aditya Sahu and Leader of the Opposition Babul Marandi, met Union Home Minister Amit Shah in New Delhi on Wednesday. The meeting discussed several issues concerning the State, including the students protest. Former CMs Arjun Munda, Raghubar Das, and Champai Soren were also present. "We told Mr. Shah due to our continuous effort by putting pressure on the Hemant Soren regime, the State government agreed to cancel all those examinations which were under suspicion," said one of the leaders present at the meeting.

Foreign national dies during
questioning at Surat station

A foreign national died during questioning at a Railway Protection Force post at Surat station after he was deported from a long-distance train following a fight with co-passengers, the Government Railway Police (GRP) said on Wednesday. The GRP had launched a custodial death investigation to ascertain the circumstances leading to his death. The man was travelling to Delhi on the Golden Temple Express after boarding at Mumbai's Borivali. Abhay Soni, Western Railway Superintendent of Police, Vadodra Division, said the man's identity and nationality was yet to be established.

State govt. to test drivers
on 'working knowledge'
of Marathi from today

Maharashtra to issue notice granting one-month grace period to learn the language, followed by licence suspension and finally permanent cancellation; ruling party leader calls it 'an injustice'

The Hindu Bureau
MUMBAI

Maharashtra Transport Minister Pratap Sarnaik on Wednesday announced a drive to act against autorickshaw and taxi drivers without a "working knowledge" of Marathi from Thursday. "The licences of autorickshaw and taxi drivers refusing to learn Marathi could lead to suspension or cancellation," warned Mr. Sarnaik.

He said functional knowledge of Marathi language among commercial vehicle drivers will be assessed and the entire process of verifying Marathi language knowledge while issuing new badges to drivers will be videographed.

The State Transport Department will send a notice to drivers who refuse to learn the language or are seen violating the rules. The notice will grant a one-month grace period to learn Marathi and authorities will suspend the li-



Additional Transport Commissioner Ravi Gaikwad will lead the month-long drive against non-Marathi taxi, auto drivers. FILE PHOTO

cence for three months if the drivers refuse to learn the language. If the situation persists thereafter, the licences will be cancelled.

Additional Transport Commissioner Ravi Gaikwad will lead the month-long drive against non-Marathi taxi and autorickshaw drivers across the State.

Regional Transport Office (RTO) flying squads have been instructed through videoconferencing to carry out checks and ensure the implementation of the amended rules.

Mr. Sarnaik reiterated that the aim is to promote Marathi and increase its usage in day-to-day conversations, saying, "If any driver openly challenges the order, it will not be tolerated and action will be taken."

After a 105-day campaign by the government to encourage non-Marathi taxi and autorickshaw drivers to learn the language, 1.65 lakh drivers received certificates of proficiency. In April, the government had also released a Marathi language guidebook in an

effort to help drivers to learn the language.

The autorickshaw drivers' and owners' association headed by Shashank Rao and Shiv Sena leader Sanjay Nirupam on Wednesday called the government decision to implement the rule immediately "an injustice" and demanded time for drivers to learn Marathi.

'Don't threaten them'

"The government should not threaten them or create an atmosphere of confrontation. They are already worried about their livelihood," said Mr. Nirupam, widely perceived as the north Indian face of the party, led by Deputy CM Eknath Shinde, in Mumbai.

He claimed that allowing RTO officials to test drivers' proficiency in Marathi could create another avenue for corruption and harassment. The former MP claimed that the Transport Minister has agreed to heed his request.

(With inputs from PTI)

Centre tells SC some
deportees brought
back from Bangladesh

Press Trust of India
NEWS DELHI

The Centre on Wednesday told the Supreme Court that certain Bengali-speaking individuals, who were sent to Bangladesh from West Bengal on suspicion of their citizenship, have been brought back to India.

A Bench comprising Chief Justice Surya Kant and Justices Joydip Bagchi and V. Mohana took note of the development and disposed of petitions filed by the Centre challenging directions of the Calcutta High Court for repatriation disposed of

Petitions filed by the Centre challenging directions of the Calcutta High Court for repatriation disposed of

proceedings pending, it said and disposed of the petitions. The Bench, however, clarified that the question of law involved in the matter was left open.

On May 22, the Centre told the Bench that it has decided to bring back some people, who were earlier deported to Bangladesh, to India and would then verify their claim of Indian citizenship.

'Peculiar facts'

The Solicitor General had said that keeping in view the peculiar facts and circumstances of the case and by not treating it as a precedent to be followed in other matters, the government has decided to bring them back.

The top court was hearing a plea of the Centre challenging a September 26, 2025 order of the Calcutta High Court by which it had set aside the Central government's decision to deport Sunali Khatun and others to Bangladesh and termed it as "illegal".

Centre has left it to States to
decide the order in which
State song should be sung: HC

Mohamed Imranullah S.
CHENNAI

The Union Ministry of Home Affairs (MHA) has left it to the State governments to decide the order in which the State song must be played, when rendered along with the national song and the national anthem during the commencement of official events, the Madras High Court has said.



The petitioner was aggrieved over Tamil *Thai Vazhthu* being pushed to the third place, after the national song and the national anthem, during Chief Minister C. Joseph Vijay's swearing-in ceremony.

PIL dismissed

Dismissing a public interest litigation petition as infructuous, the first Division Bench of Chief Justice Sushrut Arvind Dhamadhikari and Justice C. Arul Murugan said: "The Ministry's revised circular dated July 9, 2026 leaves the placement and performance of State song to the discretion of the State government."

The Bench also said

that, pursuant to the Centre's revised circular, the Tamil Nadu government had issued a Government Order reaffirming its instructions that the State song, *Tamil Thai Vazhthu*, should be sung first at the commencement of official events at educational institutions, government offices, and so on.

The submissions were made in response to the

PIL petition filed by Ananya Radhakrishnan of Chennai.

'Unhappy with order'

The petitioner was aggrieved over *Tamil Thai Vazhthu* being pushed to the third place, after the national song and the national anthem, during Chief Minister C. Joseph Vijay's swearing-in ceremony on May 10, 2026.

Cong. seeks regularisation of staff hired
through Haryana Kaushal Rozgar Nigam

The Hindu Bureau
CHANDIGARH

Congress leaders and workers staged a protest in Panchkula on Wednesday demanding that the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) government regularise all personnel recruited through the Haryana Kaushal Rozgar Nigam.

The Opposition party accused the State government of favouring the contract system over conducting regular recruitments.

Congress MPs, MLAs, and scores of party workers participated in the protest led by former Chief Minister and Leader of the Opposition in the Assembly Bhupinder Singh Hooda.

The BJP government is exploiting the youth through the Haryana Kaushal Rozgar Nigam, Mr. Hooda alleged. "We demand that all employees recruited via the Haryana Kaushal Rozgar Nigam be regularised in government



Cong. leaders and workers, led by ex-CM Bhupinder Singh Hooda, holding a protest in Panchkula on Wednesday. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

service and granted equal pay scales, Dearness Allowance, promotion avenues, reservation benefits, and retirement benefits. Also, all future appointments should be made through the regular recruitment processes," the Congress leader said.

"The government's primary duty is to conduct regular recruitments, but the BJP government is promoting the contract system by filling even gazetted posts through the Haryana

Kaushal Rozgar Nigam. This practice is indirectly undermining reservation provisions for Dalits, Backward Classes, and the poor," Mr. Hooda said.

'Govt. posts reduced'

During the Congress government's tenure, the number of government posts had been increased to four lakh to provide employment to the maximum number of youth and ensure better public services for the people, the former

CM said. "However, the BJP has reduced this figure to just 2.5 lakh, effectively making Haryana the unemployment capital of the country," he alleged.

"The Congress will continue its struggle until the government restores the number of posts to four lakh and regularises the skilled workers recruited through the Haryana Kaushal Rozgar Nigam. We are not making a new demand, rather the BJP itself had announced the regularisation of 1.25,000 skilled contractual workers to garner their votes during the previous Assembly election," Mr. Hooda said.

"Haryana ranks first in the country in terms of unemployment. Even highly qualified youth are forced to take up Class IV manual labour jobs. Under the Haryana Kaushal Rozgar Nigam, contractual personnel are deployed for a period of one year or less," the Congress leader said.

ED raids trust
premises
linked to SP's
Azam Khan

Mayank Kumar
LUCKNOW

The Enforcement Directorate (ED) on Wednesday conducted raids on premises linked to the Mohammad Ali Jauhar Trust and Mohammad Ali Jauhar University, associated with Samajwadi Party (SP) leader Azam Khan, as part of a money laundering investigation, officials said.

ED teams reached locations in Rampur, Saharanpur and Delhi, and examined financial records, documents, digital devices.

SP chief Akhilesh Yadav alleged the raids were aimed to satisfy a handful of communal, narrow-minded individuals. In a post on X, he said, "The BJP is against education and is getting schools closed, and its allies are conducting ED raids against builders of universities to satisfy their remaining 1-2% supporters."

'Operation Toofan not just policing move, it's a social movement'

Drug abuse a grave threat facing Kerala's youth, initiative to tackle network that stretches across States getting broad political support: Home Minister

INTERVIEW

Ramesh
Chennithala

Vijaita Singh

Within 76 days of the launch of Operation Toofan, Kerala's anti-drug drive, the police have registered 10,243 cases, arrested 9,941 people, and seized narcotics worth over ₹100 crore, State Home Minister Ramesh Chennithala said in an interview with *The Hindu*. Edited excerpts:

What is the vision
behind the drive?

The concern over drugs has been building for

years. When I became Home Minister, I decided that tackling the drug menace would be a priority and we launched Operation Toofan.

How is the operation
structured?

It has three parts. Toofan Strike is the enforcement wing. Toofan Warriors is the public participation component. Toofan Care focuses on rehabilitation.

How do you distinguish
between users and
traffickers?

We take a compassionate approach toward users but strong legal action against those involved in trafficking. Our aim is to ensure that trafficking becomes an



Under the drive, no one will receive protection because of political affiliation, Ramesh Chennithala said. FILE PHOTO

unviable business.

Which drugs are
commonly seized?

We have seized MDMA, ganja (cannabis), and several synthetic drugs.

Is Kerala tackling a
local problem or an
international network?

This is not just a local issue. Drug networks operate across States and international borders. We have encountered cases involving foreign nationals and supply chains that extend beyond Kerala.

How are drugs entering
Kerala?

Drugs come through sea routes, air routes, and rail networks. Traffickers also use courier services, food delivery apps, and parcel delivery systems.

How important has
coordination with other
agencies been?

It has been critical. I recently held a meeting with the police chiefs of five southern States and ap-

pointed a nodal officer for multi-agency coordination. Union Home Minister Amit Shah has offered support.

Is there political
support for the drive?

Yes. The campaign enjoys support across political lines. Drug abuse is a social issue, not a political one. We have made it clear that no one will receive protection because of political affiliation.

Does that include
people linked to
political parties?

Absolutely.

What has been the
public response?

The response has been

overwhelming. Parents, especially mothers, have strongly supported it.

Do you see any early
impact of Operation
Toofan?

Preliminary assessments suggest that there has been 30% reduction in overall crimes and 40% decline in road accidents since the crackdown began.

What is your larger
goal?

My goal is to protect the younger generation. Operation Toofan is not just a policing exercise, it is a social movement. We want government agencies and citizens to work together to eliminate the drug menace from society.

Ban on new petrol, diesel,
CNG light goods vehicles
in Delhi from Jan. 1, 2027

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

The Commission for Air Quality Management in National Capital Region and Adjoining Areas (CAQM) on Wednesday announced a phased ban on the registration of petrol, diesel, and CNG light goods vehicles (LGVs) in Delhi and the wider National Capital Region (NCR).

According to its order, registration of petrol, diesel, and CNG smaller LGVs will be banned in Delhi from January 1, 2027. The ban will come into effect in Gurugram, Faridabad, Sonapat, Ghaziabad, and Gautam Buddha Nagar from July 1, 2027. In these cities, only electric smaller LGVs or mini pick-up trucks will

be allowed to ply. For the remaining districts in the NCR, registration of petrol and diesel smaller LGVs will be banned from January 1, 2028. Both electric and CNG smaller LGVs will be permitted to ply.

The CAQM has classified LGVs into two categories: smaller LGVs (category N1) with gross vehicle weight of up to 3.5 tonnes and larger LGVs (category N2) with gross vehicle weight above 3.5 tonnes and up to 7.5 tonnes. For the N2 category, the ban will also be rolled out in phases.

"Though LGVs constitute only about 1.2% of the total active vehicle stock across the NCR, their contribution is 3.3% of PM (particulate matter) emissions," the order read.

Two students held for killing principal in Telangana

ਅੰਕੀਤ ਅਨਿਲ ਧਰੁ ਪ੍ਰੋਪਾਈਟੇਜ ਸਾਂਸਦ
ਅੰਗਣਵੀ ਸ਼ਾਲਾ ਦੇ ਮੁਖੀ-ਮਹਾਰਾਜ ਗੜ੍ਹ

ਡਾਇਰੈਕਟਰ, ਜਲਸੂਚੀ

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**OFFICE OF THE MEDICAL SUPERINTENDENT CM MEMBER SECRETARY,
RMRMS HOSPITAL, JAPUR**

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cm.smshospital@gmail.com]

No.F(4)/JCMS/SMS/2026/273 Jaipur dated, the 14/08/2026

NOTICE INVITING BID

Bids for procurement of Handheld ICG Fluorescence Imaging System & Advanced Hemodynamic system with Hypotension Prediction Technology Machine are invited from interested bidders up to 5.00 PM ON 30.09.2026. Other particular bid may be visited on the procurment portal (<http://seprocure.railshan.gov.in>)

UBN No., MC/J26T/GLCB08069

Medical Superintendent Cm Member Secretary, RMRMS Sawal Man Singh Hospital Jaipur

DIPRC/P/15294/2026

Editorial



Vote of trust

Clean electoral rolls are a must, but must not be weaponised by state

President Donald Trump's appreciation of India's election mechanism has put the spotlight on a highly divided debate over election integrity in the two democracies. Mr. Trump is pushing for an SIR-like exercise in the U.S., but its highly federalised electoral process is governed by fragmented rules and politics that resist the idea. His curious social media post citing India's Chief Election Commissioner, Gyanesh Kumar, as having wondered how the U.S. could conduct elections without a valid photo identity, has renewed concerns over election integrity in both the U.S. and India. While no one can disagree that the process should be fair and transparent, the agreement ends there. Partisan politics in both countries have fostered political mistrust, leading election losers to repeatedly question electoral integrity. The liberal and progressive strands, and the conservative and nativist strands in both countries, want to purify and streamline the electoral rolls and the processes, but in different and often contradictory ways. India and the U.S. could lead a shared democratic agenda on election rules, but only after restoring trust and integrity in their electoral processes.

India's nationalised election administration system has largely worked well, though it now faces a crisis of legitimacy. The U.S.'s decentralised system leaves too many loopholes in the process of enrolment and voting, and it could benefit from a more robust national framework like the ECI's. The expanded Safeguard American Voter Eligibility (SAVE) Act was passed in February and is pending in the Senate. The Constitution grants each State its own methods: "...but Congress may at any time by law make or alter such regulations", unlike the Indian Constitution, which establishes the ECI as a constitutional body. Though there is no ambiguity in existing law either in the U.S. or in India that only citizens may register and vote, the process of ensuring this has become hugely controversial in both countries. The proposed federal law would require proof of citizenship for voter registration and photo ID for voting. In India, the SIR is trying to sneak in this requirement without transparency, adequate consultation or sufficient time. The very fact that SIR is meant to be conducted only once in 20 years means it should be carried out carefully and inclusively. While ruling dispensations in both countries think that the election process is too permissive and allows foreigners to obtain voting rights, their opponents point to systematic and premeditated efforts to target social groups in the name of election integrity. What is needed is an acceptance that clean electoral rolls of citizens, and voting with photo ID, are elementary requirements of a fair process. In both countries, the state must not selectively weaponise these requirements against those not in power.

Due diligence

Curbs on surrogate advertising must avoid regulatory overreach

Maharashtra Food and Drug Administration (FDA) Commissioner Tukaram Mundhe's attempts to disrupt the marketing chain, by targeting the celebrities who prop up the brand recall of manufacturers' products, is an encouraging counterpoint to the consumer goods advertising landscape of today. This landscape has long suffered the consequences of a gross asymmetry: the person with the persuasive power suffers almost none of the economic downsides of consuming certain goods, a situation sustained as much by uncritical endorsement as by inequities in the public health-care system. But the FDA must still prove its suspicions. According to it, Vimal Elaiichi – which Shah Rukh Khan, Ajay Devgn and Tiger Shroff have endorsed – does not have a market identity independent of its association with tobacco and that endorsing it amounts to a surrogate endorsement of tobacco products. While this seems a reasonable reading of the Cigarettes and Other Tobacco Products Act (COTPA) Rules, the Delhi High Court, in *DGHS vs Som Pan Product Pvt. Ltd.* (2024), had held that the state had a responsibility to prove a case of surrogate advertising. That is, neither could brand registration alone prove surrogate advertising nor could the mere existence of a technically legal product permit a particular advertisement.

While Mr. Mundhe's efforts are commendable, the FDA should follow through with inquiries under COTPA and the Food Safety and Standards Act 2006 that withstand scrutiny. India bears the world's largest burden of oral cancer, and the FDA is right to treat certain advertisements as unfair trade practices with significant consequences for consumer health. The endorser liability created by the Consumer Protection Act 2019, together with hefty financial penalties, has also undermined celebrities' ability to invoke ignorance of a manufacturer's intentions as a defence. The FDA's decision to have celebrity endorsers explain their decision-making is a logical extension of this principle in the domain of enforcement. The problem exemplified by tobacco also extends to products making unsubstantiated claims (e.g., "boosts immunity"), and educational and financial products. Unfortunately, India's regulatory regime is fragmented across a slew of Acts and Rules; problematic advertisements often invoke legal and administrative instruments to draw the judiciary's intervention. Penalties or bans in the FDA's case could significantly narrow the space exploited for surrogate advertising. If the FDA fails to act fairly, however, it could become yet another example of regulatory overreach that strengthened the practices it sought to end.

A Palestinian state is the foundation for regional peace

There is one, and only one solution to the decades long, volatile and bloody situation in West Asia: the creation or the establishment of a sovereign, independent, viable Palestinian state. In essence, it is no different from the oft-touted two-state solution. But the two-state formula speaks of the establishment of two states living side by side in good neighbourliness. However, one state already exists. What is needed is to establish or create a new, second state, namely Palestine. There will never be peace and stability in the region unless this is done. All the conflicts in the region – Israel's war on Gaza, the Iran war, the Hezbollah-Israel war, the Houthi phenomenon – will not be resolved unless a viable Palestinian state comes into being. Israel's relations with its Arab neighbours will remain strained until it accepts the reality of a Palestinian state, just as the Arabs have reconciled to the reality of Israel.

United States President Donald Trump seems to have recognised the importance of working towards the creation of a Palestinian state. Resolution 2803 setting up a Board of Peace (BoP), which was adopted by the United Nations Security Council in November 2025 has the following provision in its annex: "While Gaza re-development advances and when the PA [Palestinian Authority] reform program is faithfully carried out, the conditions may finally be in place for a credible pathway to Palestinian self-determination and statehood, which we recognize as the aspiration of the Palestinian people."

On Iran and Israel

A major player in this conflict-infested region is Iran. Iran has not always been hostile to Israel. Indeed, under the Shah, Iran's relations with Israel were cordial and there was a sizeable Jewish community in Iran. Since the Islamic revolution of 1979, most Jews left for Israel. But there are still about 15,000 Jews in Iran. Iran's Constitution provides for a seat for the Jewish community in Parliament.

Historically, there has not been perpetual enmity between Islam and Judaism. The Koran mentions many prophets and patriarchs from the Hebrew bible, such as Moses, and Abraham. The Crusades were fought between Muslims and Christians; the Jews were not a party to them. Jews were persecuted in countries professing Christianity. The Arabs bore no responsibility for the Holocaust which was carried out by Nazi Germany and its collaborators. It would not be an



C.R. Gharekhan

Former United Nations Coordinator for Occupied Territories and Special Envoy of India for West Asia

exaggeration to say that but for the Holocaust, and the sense of guilt felt by the western countries, Israel might not have been born. It is well known that most western countries, including the U.S., barred the entry of Jews seeking refuge from Hitler's Germany.

The transition from holy land to homeland started with the infamous Balfour Declaration of 1917 when the British expressed support for a homeland for the Jews, expressly limiting the indigenous Arab population only to civil and religious rights.

The roots of regional hostility

The hostility of Iran and the Arab countries towards Israel is based on the fact that Israel was created and imposed on the region at the expense of the indigenous Arab population. It is argued that the Palestinians were offered a state in the UN resolution of 1947 and a few times subsequently, but they rejected all offers. An Israeli Foreign Minister, Abba Eban, famously said that the Arabs never miss an opportunity to miss an opportunity. But one can hardly blame a landlord if he rejects an offer of a few rooms from an intruder who has occupied the whole house. Indeed, the slogan of the Zionists was: land without people for a people without land.

It is noteworthy that Hezbollah, a Shia movement, and Iran, a Shia-majority country, support Hamas, a Sunni movement. This is easily explained by their commitment to the right of self-determination for the Palestinian people. Israel naturally comes in for hostility as the only power that stands in the way of the emergence of an independent Palestine.

Hezbollah began launching rockets and missiles against Israel just after Israel started its war on Gaza after October 7, 2023. It follows that if Israel accepts the reality of a Palestinian state at some time, Hezbollah will have no reason to make the life of people in northern Israel difficult.

In that case, Iran too will stop supplying weapons to Hezbollah. This is not to suggest that if the Palestinians are able to exercise their right of self-determination, Iran and Israel will become friends. But without that, their mutual enmity will never abate. If an irreversible road map to a Palestinian state emerges and is accepted by all the parties, secondary issues such as the Strait of Hormuz will be much easier to resolve.

Since Hamas' terrorist attack on Israeli civilians in October 2023, whatever little support some in Israel had for the concept of a Palestinian state has evaporated. Israel's disproportionate and

ruthless strikes on Gaza, post October 7, might have almost isolated Israel, but in the process, the Gaza strip has been devastated and the possibility of the emergence of Palestine has receded by many years, perhaps decades. Consequently, peace and stability in the region have become an illusion.

Mediation is the key

The only way to have a realistic possibility of resolving the conflict is through external mediation. And the only external power that has the required influence and even goodwill with both sides is the United States. It is true that there is no such thing as an honest broker. But brokers, even non-honest ones, do manage to sell the transaction to the satisfaction, or equal non-satisfaction, of both parties.

Israel has insisted on bilateral talks, adding at the same time that there is no one on the other side to negotiate with. Usually, the stronger side insists on a bilateral approach, and the weaker side prefers an outside agency to help. The only time progress was achieved was when the Oslo Accord was concluded in 1993. Oslo was negotiated with the mediation or good offices of Norway.

Under Oslo, the Palestine Liberation Organization formally recognised Israel and the PA was created; it is this PA, albeit a reformed one, that is often mentioned as a possible caretaker government of Palestine. The Oslo Accords paved the way for Jordan's recognition of Israel and eventually the Abraham Accords.

The other viable broker is the UN. Israel at the moment is dead set against the UN and has even declared the UN Secretary-General *persona non grata*. But Israel owes its existence to the UN. There is nothing permanent in international relations. Positions evolve with evolving situations.

Israeli Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu has his own personal reasons for opposing the idea of an independent Palestine. He had voted against the Oslo Accords and is implacably opposed to the idea of a Palestine state.

Let us hope that in due course, enlightened leadership will emerge in West Asia on all sides. If the leaders do not have the wisdom and the courage to make the necessary decisions, however difficult, the people of the region will remain doomed to suffer and be denied the peace and stability they need. Without these, they will never be able to realise the full potential for development that new technologies have to offer.

Before new taxes, making every rupee count

Every Budget season in Tamil Nadu produces the same refrain: The state needs more money, the Centre owes the State more, and taxpayers must prepare for new levies. The first Budget of the Tamil Nadu Vettri Kazhagam (TVK) begins with a different question: before asking citizens for another rupee, has the State collected every rupee legally due to it – and spent what it has as well as it should?

The data, the facts

Tamil Nadu's fiscal position is genuinely difficult. Debt is high, the revenue account remains in deficit, and salaries, pensions, welfare and interest payments leave limited room to manoeuvre. None of that is in dispute. What is in dispute is whether the response should begin with new taxation, or with making the State's existing revenue collection and expenditure substantially more efficient.

The Comptroller and Auditor General of India's (CAG) own numbers make the case. In 2023-24, Tamil Nadu budgeted about ₹4.47 lakh crore and spent roughly ₹4.14 lakh crore – a net underspend of ₹33,302.53 crore. Separately, ₹1,078 crore in supplementary provisions across 81 cases in 26 grants was found to be unnecessary because the original allocations had not even been exhausted.

The same audit records that 2.89% of revenue expenditure and 6.14% of revenue receipts had not been reconciled with the Accountant General's own records. None of this is proof of corruption. It is evidence that budgeting and accounting systems can be considerably more disciplined.

This is the argument for zero-based budgeting: an allocation should not continue automatically because it appeared in last year's Budget; it should justify its continuation and its amount. This writer has seen the idea take shape



Americal V. Narayanan

National Spokesperson of the Tamil Nadu Vettri Kazhagam (TVK), a certified public accountant (CPA) and a certified management accountant (CMA) with an MBA (all from the U.S.)

first-hand in the United States, where Jimmy Carter used zero-based budgeting as Governor of Georgia and later introduced it into the federal budget process as President. Tamil Nadu adopted the same principle on paper in 1988, the very year Carter's own experiment had long since faded from Washington. It never became the governing discipline of the Budget here. Paired with performance-based budgeting – not how many cores were released for road works, but how many kilometres were built, at what cost, and to what standard – it stops to be an accounting exercise and becomes a management tool.

Data-driven governance standards

Numbers discipline government only when they are measurable and comparable. As a starting point, the TVK government should work toward department-wise performance data alongside comparable figures from other States and, where available, the Union government – cost per kilometre of road, cost per household connected to piped water, administrative cost per welfare rupee delivered. It can begin where data is most readily available and expand as systems improve, rather than promise a complete comparison on day one.

There is already a live example of what competition does to cost. When the Greater Chennai Corporation opened smaller road-restoration contracts to wider bidding, a ₹25 lakh Ambattur project drew nine contractors and closed 25.9% below the official estimate. That is not proof that the whole system was previously running 25% over cost – a lower bid still has to deliver the same specifications, and one tender cycle is not a trend. But it is a working demonstration that transparent competition can create real fiscal value without a single new tax. The same logic applies to revenue. A separate

CAG audit flagged ₹1,538.18 crore in irregularities across 337 Goods and Services Tax (GST) cases, of which only ₹8.64 crore had been recovered at the time of audit, alongside 244 taxpayers operating outside the GST net altogether.

These are audit findings requiring verification and due process, not revenue the government can book today. But they point to an obvious principle: before raising rates on people who are already paying honestly, exhaust the scope for improving compliance and collection efficiency. This is the brief given to the Montek Singh Ahluwalia-led Revenue Augmentation Committee – not simply to look for new taxes, but to close compliance gaps, rationalise exemptions, and identify revenue that the State is currently failing to collect.

Spending to outcomes

The same discipline has to apply on the spending side. The government has announced a high-level Expenditure Reforms Committee to review schemes for their impact and ensure that resources reach intended beneficiaries without restricting genuine welfare expansion. This is where performance-based budgeting becomes critical. The question is not merely how much was allocated or spent, but what that expenditure produced: how many kilometres of road were built, how many households received reliable drinking water, how many students gained measurable educational outcomes, and how many beneficiaries actually received the intended support.

This is not an argument for less welfare. It is an argument for welfare that can be measured.

Fix the leaks first. Spend against outcomes, not habit. Then decide what, if anything, still needs to be asked of the taxpayer. That is the standard that the TVK will hold this Budget to – and the standard it intends to hold itself to.

LETTERS TO THE EDITOR

Guard against overreach

Students constitute the intellectual vanguard of a nation and have an inalienable right to articulate their grievances through peaceful and democratic means. The indiscriminate registration of criminal cases against genuine protesters can have deleterious repercussions on their academic pursuits, professional prospects, and psychological well-being. The Supreme Court of India's intervention is a salutary reminder that the majesty of the law must coexist with freedom of expression and the democratic right to dissent

(Front page, "Ready to drop FIRs against student protesters," says SC," August 19). Justice must be administered with impartiality, restraint, and compassion so that the future of innocent students is not imperilled by unwarranted criminal proceedings. **Nagarajam M.V.,** Hyderabad

Issue with centralisation

The National Testing Agency (NTA)'s decision to hold re-examinations in three subjects confirms the agency's continuing callousness. India has enough talent, but what it

lacks is the will to strive for perfection. It has been proved beyond doubt that the NTA cannot improve, making it imperative to find a viable and meaningful alternative. The obsession with centralising everything, including entrance examinations, has proved meaningless and wasteful. The better course would be to leave education and health care to the States, providing funds wherever necessary. States such as Tamil Nadu and Kerala achieved great heights when these two sectors were under the States' purview. Now, instead of other States catching up

with them, poor quality is being universalised. A policy change is therefore imminent. **A.G. Rajmohan,** Anantapur, Andhra Pradesh

Black money and polls

The Supreme Court of India hit the nail on the head when it observed that black money in the electoral process compromises democracy, the rule of law and the electoral process itself (Inside pages, August 18). The Election Commission of India must ensure free and fair elections, for which political parties and citizens must cooperate. One feels that

Generation Z, which took the nation by storm through its recent protests against the National Eligibility cum Entrance Test (NEET) fiasco and succeeded, can take up this serious issue as well. **S. Ramakrishnasayee,** Chennai

Faulty roll revision

The government and the Election Commission of India may have the backing of the Supreme Court to clean voter lists of duplicate, fake and non-existent voters. But who authorised them to declare a living voter 'permanently shifted or dead'? My spouse

submitted her Special Intensive Revision form online, as the Booth Level Officer never visited, and received an acknowledgment. Yet, in Telangana's recently released draft electoral roll, her name is missing. On checking further, we found it listed under "Permanently Shifted/Dead." How can a living voter be declared dead or permanently shifted without verification or even a visit to her residence? **N. Nagarajan,** Secunderabad

Letters emailed to letters@thehindu.co.in must carry the postal address.

The IISERs have a leadership problem

The Indian government created the Indian Institutes of Science Education and Research (IISERs) to offer students an intellectually vibrant research environment and to bring them into research at a relatively – vis-à-vis the Indian milieu – early stage.

The institutions prize autonomy as an essential ingredient of good science, including in the form of scientists being able to decide which questions are worth pursuing and with what resources. Top-down control is inimical to this vision. That said, the government also brought the IISERs within the statutory framework of the National Institutes of Technology, Science Education and Research Act 2007, which required each IISER to have a Board of Governors that included senior government officials and other government nominees. The IISER statutes specify, among others, the secretary of higher education and the director of the Indian Institute of Science (IISc), Bengaluru too.

While publicly funded science should be publicly accountable, suboptimal appointments or outright vacancies are objectionable as they can lead to policy paralysis – at best.

Multiple roles

Consider the current composition of the seven IISER Boards.

The IISc director is an ex-officio member of most IISERs. The chair of IISER Pune's Board is also the chairperson of the Visvesvaraya National Institute of Technology, Nagpur. The chair of the IISER Berhampur Board was given "additional charge" while also chairing the Board of IIT Guwahati; the Board also has nominated positions lying vacant, including one for an IIT director and two for eminent scientists.

IISER Bhopal's current director is listed as the "director-in-charge" after their predecessor, Gobardhan Das, left to join NTIT Ayodhya in June. At IISER



Vasudevan Mukunth

Thiruvananthapuram, the chairperson simultaneously chairs the Boards of IIT Kottayam and the Indian Institute of Information Technology, Design and Manufacturing, Kurnool.

There are also signs of churn among sitting government officials. Interim appointments are routine and vacancies can arise during transitions. Ex-officio positions also change when officials move between posts. But taken together, several IISERs are operating under temporary or incomplete leadership.

A closer look at the qualifications of the extant leaders also raises questions.

IISER Pune chairperson M. Madan Gopal is a retired IAS officer whose educational background is in commerce and journalism. Its director is a chemical engineer by training, whereas the IISERs have little focus on engineering. IISER Thiruvananthapuram chairperson Vijayalakshmi Deshmone is a surgeon. IISER Tirupati chairperson Hari Bharti is a chemical engineer and co-founder of the Jubilant Bharati Group. IISER Berhampur chairperson Satyabrata Dey is an executive in the footwear industry.

While there is no rule that the chairperson of a scientific institution must be a scientist, its matters for each institution's credibility and vision

While there is no rule that the chairperson of a scientific institution must be a scientist, its matters for each institution's credibility and vision

and research organisations.

The question is not about the competence of the current crop of leaders but why India's many accomplished scientists are not being asked to lead institutions whose central purpose is basic science.

The availability of this 'research cadre' also calls into question the practice of moving the same people between institutions.

People familiar with the IISERs' functioning today describe a situation where the administration is losing its ability to keep up with students' needs vis-à-vis a good education in basic science. By design, the directors and the Board have the power to institute positive changes. However, as a senior scientist at one of the IISERs put it, "There is no vision or imagination and no sense of leadership propelling the institution towards its core goals of carrying out high-quality frontier research in and teaching basic science at an international level."

Weakening autonomy

The Indian government's choices are weakening the IISERs' institutional autonomy. With 'outsiders' and people whose attention is already divided between multiple institutions as leaders, scientists have less control over decisions that affect their work.

An institution whose governance has begun to decline can still remain scientifically productive for many years as long as the people who built its reputation remain and the 'IISER' label is still valuable. But given the cumulative effects of the IISERs' flagging leadership – of the institutions becoming less autonomous and less collegial – it is reasonable to brace for more warning signs, including concentration of authority and an increasingly risk-averse institutional culture.

None of them is conducive to good science or a good education.

mukunth.v@thehindu.co.in

Tamil Nadu's encroachment problem

The SC has pulled up the State for not dealing with encroachers in Agasthyamalai

STATE OF PLAY

B. Aravind Kumar

Frustrated by the Tamil Nadu government's inability to evict "encroachers" in the Agasthyamalai landscape, the Supreme Court recently said the matter required a structured, time bound, and closely monitored framework. A Bench of Justices Vikram Nath and Sandeep Mehta said that encroachments within the protected areas of the Agasthyamalai landscape, including the Kala-kad Mundanthur Tiger Reserve, the Srivilliputhur-Megamalai Tiger Reserve and the Kanyakumari Wildlife Sanctuary, have persisted over decades despite specific directions issued by the Madras High Court and the top court.

In fact, the Supreme Court went as far to suggest using the paramilitary to evict the encroachers to preserve and protect the ecologically sensitive regions.

The CEC report

Last year, the top court had directed the Central Empowered Committee (CEC) to conduct an extensive survey of the Agasthyamalai landscape in order to identify all instances of non-forestry activities going on contrary to the Forest Conservation Act, 1980 and the Wild Life (Protection) Act, 1972 etc. The CEC submitted its interim report and made several recommendations, including a time-bound, division-wise encroachment eviction plan.

With regard to the Kanyakumari Wildlife Sanctuary, the CEC reported sizeable encroachment, and non-availability of verified maps of the reserve forest. An area of 427.40 hectares has been en-



croached with 237.09 hectares involved in litigation. The report said that whenever the Forest Department had attempted evictions, law and order issues have arisen; a joint effort would be necessary.

Further, the CEC observed that the Srivilliputhur-Megamalai Tiger Reserve is one of the most ecologically vulnerable areas, as it forms the upper catchment of the Vaigai River, a critical water source for five downstream districts. As per official records of 2020, around 4,595 individuals are encroaching upon 5,071.27 hectares of reserved forest land. The CEC noted that these encroachments are old, with many of them involved in the permanent cultivation of crops such as silk cotton, cardamom, and beans, and that in spite of clear orders from the High Court to remove encroachments, no significant progress has been made so far. Moreover, a total of 116 government and public utility structures have been constructed inside forest lands without prior approval. Alarmingly, a total of 118 individuals listed as encroachers have been identified as serving or retired government employees, including personnel from the Army, Police, Forest Department, and other State departments.

With respect to the Kala-kad-Mundanthur Tiger Reserve, the CEC reported that the total extent of encroach-

ment is 10.16 hectares by 998 families.

The State's response

In reply to the CEC report, the State of Tamil Nadu filed a detailed affidavit listing the steps taken by the authorities. It candidly acknowledged the challenges faced such as resistance from encroachers, ongoing court cases, and that many encroachers were landless and from economically weaker sections.

While the SC judges acknowledged the complexity of the rehabilitation task was real and could not be understated, it however could not be a perpetual justification for the indefinite postponement of legally mandated eviction and restoration measures, they noted. The top court directed that disciplinary and legal action be initiated against all identified 118 Government servants found to be encroachers. It also sought a blanket moratorium on the extension of welfare schemes, public utilities, transport facilities, electricity supply, and infrastructure support within encroached forest areas, so as to ensure that illegal occupation is neither incentivised nor legitimised. It also ordered a complete prohibition on approval or commencement of any new non-forestry activity within Agasthyamalai.

With such clear directions, the new coalition government led by C. Joseph Vijay has a tough task ahead, especially with the two major Dravidian parties in the Opposition likely to oppose it as it involves the eviction of thousands of families. The government also has the humongous task of resetting and rehabilitating the displaced families as well as restoring the original forests.

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Erratic Trump left with few exits in Iran war

Increased war costs and depleting critical munitions indicate that the U.S. is caught in a bind in the ongoing Iran-Israel-U.S. conflict

DATA POINT

Sambavi Parthasarathy
Gauri Singavarapu

The expiry of the U.S.'s Memorandum of Understanding with Iran on Monday with no indication of any extension has left Washington with no clear exit strategy, six months since it launched attacks on Iran along with Israel. This is evidenced in President Donald Trump's erratic stances on the war, expressed via his statements (Chart 1).

The chart shows an alternation between crude threats of destruction – for instance on March 21, he said that U.S. will destroy Iran's power plants if Tehran didn't fully open the Strait of Hormuz – and softened rhetoric when three days later he said that the U.S. and Iran had a productive conversation about resolution (denied by the Iranians). The yo-yo nature of his statements show how the Trump administration has been stuck in a quagmire following its actions, which lacked a clear strategic objective for the Americans. Rising fuel and fertilizer prices, the increased costs of waging the war, and the weakening of military advantages have caught it in a bind.

Contrary to Mr. Trump's assertions on the weakening of Tehran, Iran has not budged from its positions, despite being subject to intense bombing and a renewed naval blockade.

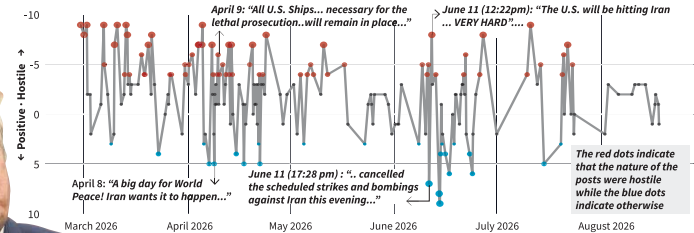
Meanwhile, the aerial bombing, missiles and drone-led retaliations by Iran have created a new bottleneck for the U.S. and its allies, who are running low on critical munitions. (Table 2).

This will also come at a great cost. According to estimates by CSIS, the Trump administration's actions in Iran, till June alone, have already incurred huge costs (~\$40 billion) (Table 1). Iran's determination to withstand the blockade is costing the U.S. both militarily and monetarily.

Caught in a bind

The data for the charts were sourced from Truthsocial, Centre for Strategic and International Studies (CSIS), and Armed Conflict Location & Event Data (ACLED)

CHART 1: The chart plots U.S. President Trump's Truth Social posts related to Iran since Feb. 28, 2026



For the above chart, The Hindu scraped and analysed around 187 Iran-related posts made by Mr. Trump on his Truth Social account. 'Re-Tweets' or reposts, posts that did not mention anything on Iran war, or posts containing quoted article links and images were not included in the analysis

CHART 2: Events of attacks by the U.S. and Iran in the ongoing conflict. Attacks refer to shelling, artillery, missile attacks, air/ drone strikes, and interceptions

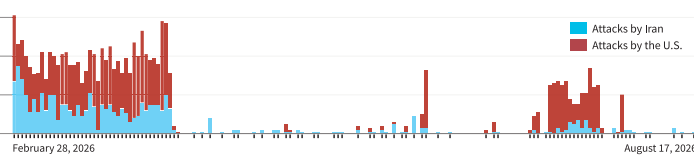


TABLE 1: Estimated cost of the Iran war for the U.S.

Category	Cost	Remarks
Deployment/ Re-deployment	\$0.17 bn	Most activities already in budget
Munitions	\$26.1 bn	Main driver of war costs
Higher operational tempo	\$0.75 bn	Includes personnel benefits
Equipment losses	\$1.7-\$5.5 bn	Aircraft and major ground equipment
Base damage	\$4.0-\$9.4 bn	Structures and interior content
Other DOD costs	\$1.5 bn	Higher fuel costs, infrastructure security
Total	\$34.2-\$41.5 bn	

The estimates by CSIS is as of June 23, 2026 and predates ceasefire violations and latest developments. The actual cost of the prolonging conflict could be much higher

Gauri Singavarapu is interning with The Hindu's Data team

TABLE 2: Cost of select expended ground attack and air defence munitions and their rate of production

Munition Type	Units expended	Unit Cost	Cost to replace expended munitions	Production rate (munitions per Year)	Orders placed for FY26	Total delivery time (In months)
Tomahawk	1000+	\$2.6 M	\$2.8 B	79	57	47
JASSM (Joint Air-to-Surface Standoff Missile)	1100+	\$1.9 M	\$2.3 B	385	144	48
PrSM (Precision Strike Missile)/ATACMS (Army Tactical Missile System)	150-380	\$1.6 M	\$0.5 B	56	45	46
Patriot (PAC-3)	1,060-1,430	\$4.9 M	\$5.3-\$7.1 B	183	233	42
THAAD (Terminal High Altitude Area Defense)	190-290	\$11.9 M	\$2.3-\$3.5 B	28	25	53
SM-3 (Standard Missile-3)	130-250	\$28.7 M	\$3.9-\$7.5 B	53	12	64
SM-2/6 (Standard Missile-2/6)	190-370	\$4.3 M	\$0.8-\$1.6 B	96	10	53

The estimates for munitions expended is as of June 2026. Replacing existing munitions alone will cost the Trump administration around \$26 billion. However, it is not just the cost that matters. The U.S. is also running low on time to replace these critical munitions as they have a lengthy production timeline

FROM THE ARCHIVES

The Hindu

FIFTY YEARS AGO AUGUST 20, 1976

Wandiwash Fort to be preserved as monument

Madras, August 19: The Fort at Wandiwash in north Arcot district, where a battle was fought between the English and the French in mid-18th century AD, now in ruins is to be preserved as a monument of State importance by the Tamil Nadu Government.

The Battle of Wandiwash (1760 AD) practically ended the French supremacy and marked the triumph and ascendancy of the British regime in South India.

Extending over a square mile, the Fort, which is right in the midst of the town is in a state of neglect. It is a village by itself. The ramparts, except in a small portion are intact. There is a big entrance. In the centre, many residential buildings have sprung up over the years. Necessary funds have now been sanctioned by the Government to protect this historic Fort.

There are no records about the origin of this Fort, but experts feel that it must have been the hub of activity in the Vijayanagar period (13th-16th century). It fell into the hands of the British around 1750 AD when Hyder Ali captured it from them. He entered Wandiwash via Chengam and Tiruvannamalai and after taking the Fort, stayed in Vellore. The British recaptured it from the Muslim ruler a year later. Again, Wandiwash was the scene of a major battle between the French and the British in January 1760, the former led by Count de Lally and the latter's army by Sir Eyrecoote. The French were defeated and Bussy, one of the prominent leaders, was captured.

A HUNDRED YEARS AGO AUGUST 20, 1926

Floods in Burma

Rangoon, August 19: A telephone message from Pegu states water is going down. Approximate estimate has been made of rice in the town and there is no danger of a general shortage of food; but a certain number of people are running short in their houses and arrangements are being made to distribute to them, the main difficulty is transport.

Four first class passengers who were stranded at Payagi had reached Pegu and proceeded to Rangoon. Both the Hon'ble Ministers are still (last night) at Payagi. There is no news from the other towns further up the line (Pyuntaya Daiki etc) as the telegraph line is apparently broken.

Text & Context

THE HINDU

NEWS IN NUMBERS

China's youth unemployment rate in July

17.9 in per cent. China's youth unemployment rate rose to 17.9% in July, the second-highest level in recent years, according to the National Bureau of Statistics. The rise coincided with a record 12.7 million university graduates entering the job market. PTI

Black Americans elected as governors in U.S. history

3 Across 250 years, only three elected governors in the United States have been Black, including Maryland Governor Wes Moore. With Florida Republicans nominating Congressman Byron Donalds, there are now eight Black major-party gubernatorial nominees on November ballots this year. AP

Excess deaths recorded in France during July heatwave

1,243 France recorded 1,243 excess deaths between July 2 and 22 during a heatwave, according to the national public health agency. The figure brings the still provisional number of excess deaths during this year's periods of high temperatures to 7,300. AFP

Police personnel from specialised units redeployed

513 The Telangana Police Department is rationalising its manpower by redeploying personnel from specialised units to meet the changing nature of crime and public safety challenges. As part of this, 513 personnel are being redeployed to eight departments. PTI

Electors marked under ASDDO categories in SIR in Karnataka

1.07 in crore. More than 1.07 crore electors have been marked under the Absent, Shifted, Dead, Duplicate, and Others (ASDDO) category during the ongoing SIR of electoral rolls in Karnataka, officials said on Wednesday. PTI
COMPILED BY THE HINDU DATA TEAM

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The myth called 'perfect victim'

The Tejpal case shows how the 'ideal victim' stereotype can shape judicial perceptions, with survivors often judged by their behaviour and personal background rather than the evidence; such assumptions have created a hierarchy of victimisation, prompting the court to call for greater gender sensitivity in judicial writing

LETTER & SPIRIT

Grace Paul Vallooran

On August 6, the Goa Division Bench of the Bombay High Court set aside the 2021 judgment of the trial court that had acquitted Tarun Tejpal. The High Court convicted Tejpal, the former editor of *Tehelka* magazine, and sentenced him to 10 years of rigorous imprisonment for raping a former colleague.

While terming the trial court's ruling "perverse", the High Court also said that it had fallen for the notion that a sexual assault complainant must be a 'perfect victim' and conduct herself in a certain way to appear credible.

Nils Christie's concept

What is the idea of a 'perfect victim' or an 'ideal victim'? It was theorised by Norwegian criminologist Nils Christie in a chapter of the same name, in the book *From Crime Policy to Victim Policy*, in 1986.

Christie said the 'ideal victim' or 'perfect victim' possesses five main attributes. First, they are often female, disabled, very young, or very old, and are therefore weak in relation to the offender. Second, they are involved in "respectable activities". Third, they cannot reasonably be blamed for being where they were during the crime. Fourth, they do not know the offender personally. Fifth, they are attacked by a perpetrator who is "big and bad". Christie also noted that while being weak, the victim must have enough social power to influence sympathy and have their victim status recognised.

This one-size-fits-all idea of victimhood is propagated widely — by the media, social media, films, and by the larger society. Race, class, gender and other factors are involved in these dramatic portrayals where the most "innocent" and "deserving" become the 'ideal victim' while others are viewed as "undeserving" of sympathy, Christie argued.

In contrast to the idea of the 'ideal



GETTY IMAGES

victim' is the idea of the 'ideal offender'. According to Christie, such an individual must be framed as purely bad, dangerous, and a stranger to the victim so that it becomes easy for society not to like him. When the offender is a familiar person with a "good background story", the 'ideal' dynamic breaks down.

In the case of Tejpal, his social status and his image as a liberal intellectual complicated this stereotype of the 'ideal offender'. As per Christie's argument, when there is no 'ideal offender' to hate, it becomes hard to perceive an 'ideal victim' to sympathise with.

Hierarchy of victimisation

This narrow perception of an 'ideal victim' creates a hierarchy of victimisation. Those who are thought of as "undeserving" are even perceived as contributing to the situation and receive less sympathy or none at all.

For instance, in the 1979 Mathura custodial rape case of a teenager, the Sessions Court had relied on the survivor's previous sexual experience to reason that she had likely consented, and described her as "habituated to sexual intercourse". The Supreme Court, while

acquitting the accused policemen, noted the absence of any alarm or resistance from the survivor or injuries on her body.

Similarly, in the gang-rape case of social worker Bhanwari Devi (1992) that became a catalyst for the formulation of the Vishakha guidelines and later, the enactment of the Sexual Harassment of Women at Workplace (Prevention, Prohibition and Redressal) Act, 2013, the Jaipur District and Sessions Court in 1995 acquitted the accused of gang rape. The court reasoned that it was unlikely that upper caste men would "pollute" themselves by having sexual relations with a Dalit woman. In short, in the eyes of the court, Devi's caste status made her an unlikely 'ideal victim'.

In 2017, in an interim order, a Punjab and Haryana High Court division bench suspended the sentences and granted bail to three former Jindal Global Law School students convicted of gang-raping and blackmailing a classmate. It described the survivor's behaviour as having a "perverse streak".

The court said, "...We are conscious of the fact that allegations of the victim regarding her being threatened into submission and blackmail lend sufficient

diabolism to the offence, but a careful examination of her statement again offers an alternate conclusion of misadventure stemming from a promiscuous attitude and a voyeuristic mind." This remark placed the survivor's sexual behaviour at the centre of the court's assessment, effectively questioning her status as an 'ideal victim'.

These rulings have demanded a 'performance' of trauma from survivors. Any digression from that expected behaviour has cast doubts on the survivors' credibility and status as legitimate. The rulings reflect Christie's theory that victimhood is not an objective state, but a deeply gendered moral status that can be granted or denied by society.

The Tejpal case

In 2021, in the Tejpal case, the Goa Sessions Court noted that there were several discrepancies in the survivor's versions. It also said that while the victim had claimed to be in shock and trauma after exiting the lift on November 7, 2013, the CCTV footage showed that she was composed and smiling.

The High Court criticised the Sessions Court for focusing on the complainant's conduct, reactions, and personal background instead of the evidence on record. It also noted that a survivor has already faced trauma and might feel too ashamed, nervous, or confused to respond clearly when questioned repeatedly in an unfamiliar environment.

The Supreme Court has questioned this idea in some of its judgments. In 2025, former Chief Justice B.R. Gavai had apologised on behalf of the judiciary for the Supreme Court judgment in the Mathura case, calling it a "moment of institutional embarrassment".

Recently, on August 3, the Supreme Court issued a report recommending greater gender sensitivity in judicial writing. It cautioned judges against drawing adverse conclusions from delayed reporting, lack of physical injuries, inconsistencies in testimony or a survivor's demeanour, noting that trauma affects people differently.

THE GIST

▼ Nils Christie's 'ideal victim' theory holds that vulnerability, respectability and innocence shape who is perceived as deserving of sympathy.

▼ Court rulings in cases such as Mathura, Bhanwari Devi and Tejpal show how survivors' behaviour and personal circumstances have been used to question their credibility.

▼ The Supreme Court has recently urged judges to avoid such assumptions, noting that trauma can affect survivors differently.

Why is the Supreme Court examining polygamy again?

What are the petitioners seeking? What has the court ruled on polygamy before?

Ziya Us Salam

The story so far:

The Muslim men's supposed right to have multiple wives is once again before the Supreme Court. Following a petition challenging the constitutional status of polygamy, the court sought the Centre's response last week. It also asked the Centre to consider taking suitable legislative steps to abolish the practice for all citizens, irrespective of religion. The petition was filed by five activists, who sought to have polygamy treated as a criminal offence under Section 82 of the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita.

Incidentally, Section 82 applies to non-Muslims and provides for a punishment of up to seven years for marrying another person during the subsistence of an existing marriage. The petitioners also sought annulment of the exemptions granted under Muslim Personal Law.

What are the petitioners seeking?

The five petitioners challenged the constitutional validity of Section 2 of the Muslim Personal Law (Shariat) Application Act, 1937, which permits polygamy. They claimed that the said Act is against the Constitution's Articles 14, 15, and 16, which provide equality to all citizens irrespective of their religion or gender. They also requested the court to direct the Union government to take steps towards the codification of Muslim Personal Law to ensure that its provisions run parallel to Constitutional provisions of gender equality.

They sought compulsory registration of Muslim marriages and divorces with State authorities to prevent any second or subsequent marriage of a man with a subsisting marriage. In case this was flouted, the first wife and children should have the first and lasting right to the matrimonial home.

The petitioners also sought the court to direct the Law Commission of India or the

Union government to prepare a draft for the codification of Muslim Personal Law that aligns marriage, divorce, and succession with constitutional principles of gender equality. Incidentally, two of the activists had reached out to the Supreme Court to prohibit instant triple talaq in the famous Shayara Bano and others case. Then too, they argued that the practice of triple talaq violates fundamental rights of women. Following their petition, the apex court had invalidated instant triple talaq in August 2017. The court had then refrained from giving its verdict on polygamy and nikah halala, which too had been sought. Following the verdict, the Centre framed the Muslim Women (Protection of Rights on Marriage) Act in 2019. The Act made instant triple talaq a punishable offence.

What has the court ruled before?

In the much-talked-about Sarla Mudgal case of 1995, the Supreme Court prohibited a Hindu man with a subsisting

marriage from converting to Islam purely for the purpose of marrying for the second time. The court noted, "the second marriage of a Hindu husband after converting to Islam without having dissolved the first marriage is void."

The court ruled on similar lines in the *Lily Thomas v. Union of India* case in 2000. Here the Supreme Court reiterated its stand of the Sarla Mudgal case, holding that a second marriage contracted after a feigned conversion to Islam was illegal and punishable under Section 494 of the Indian Penal Code.

Does Islam sanction polygamy?

Contrary to the contention that the Quran encourages polygamy, the book encourages monogamy. It permits a man to have up to four wives in special circumstances, such as marrying a widow or an orphan. It, however, makes it incumbent upon him to grant them complete equality. This being a practical impossibility, it asks men to desist from multiple marriages.

Says verse 3 of Surah Nisa, "If you fear you might fail to give orphan women their due rights if you were to marry them, then marry other women of your choice — two, three, or four. But if you are afraid you will fail to maintain justice, then content yourselves with one." Pertinently, this verse was revealed at a time when many men used to have multiple spouses, their numbers often running into three figures.

THE GIST

▼ The Supreme Court has sought the Centre's response to a petition challenging polygamy under Muslim Personal Law and asked it to consider legislative steps to abolish the practice for all citizens, irrespective of religion.

▼ The petitioners have challenged the constitutional validity of the law permitting polygamy, seeking its criminalisation, compulsory registration of Muslim marriages and divorces, and codification of Muslim Personal Law in line with gender equality.

KEYWORD

Punjab's decade-long journey towards a formal sacrilege law

Punjab has made repeated attempts to enact a stringent sacrilege law, with earlier Bills facing constitutional objections and the latest State law now under challenge; the 2026 law raises questions of equality, proportionality, federal legislative competence and secularism

Prathmesh Kher

Punjab's journey towards a codified sacrilege law illustrates how these pressures play out at the State level. In 2016, the then Akali Dal-BJP government passed a bill imposing life imprisonment for sacrilege committed specifically against the Guru Granth Sahib. The Centre returned it, objecting that a law protecting only one religion's scripture could not sit easily with India's secular Constitution. In 2018, the succeeding Congress government tried again, this time extending the same life sentence to the Guru Granth Sahib, the Bhagavad Gita, the Quran, and the Bible through a new Section 295AA of the Penal Code. That Bill, too, was returned without Presidential assent.

A further attempt followed in July 2025, when the Aam Aadmi Party government introduced the Punjab Prevention of Offences Against Holy Scripture(s) Bill, again covering all four texts, with sentences ranging from ten years to life. That Bill was sent to a select committee and has since been effectively shelved. Instead, the State government found a narrower route: rather than amending the central Penal Code, it amended an existing State law concerned specifically with the ceremonial custody of the Guru Granth Sahib. Because this technically falls within the State's own legislative competence, the government argued that it requires no Presidential assent, and the Governor's signature was enough to bring it into force in April 2026.

The manoeuvre has not gone unchallenged. A petition before the Punjab and Haryana High Court argues that a life sentence is a matter of criminal law, which sits on the Concurrent List and therefore cannot simply bypass central scrutiny by dressing itself up as an amendment to a ceremonial statute. Critics have also pointed out that, in covering only the Sikh scripture, the current law revives precisely the objection that sank the 2016 attempt: a State cannot credibly claim to be protecting "communal harmony" while legislating in favour of one faith's sentiments and not another's. Whichever way the litigation goes, the sequence of events across a decade shows a State legislature persistently trying, by one route or another, to entrench a sacrilege code of ever-increasing severity, undeterred by repeated constitutional rebuffs.

The constitutional contradiction Secularism was declared part of the Constitution's unamendable "basic structure" in *S.R. Bommai versus Union of India*, precisely so that the State could neither favour a religion nor punish disrespect towards one. Article 25 guarantees not just the right to practise religion but, implicitly, the space for social reformers, sceptics and atheists to challenge religious practise, since the same article subjects the right to religious freedom to "public order, morality and health" and permits the State to legislate for social welfare and reform even where this cuts against religious custom. Article 19(1)(a) guarantees free speech in the same breath that Article 19(2) permits "reasonable restrictions" in the interests



Faith and law: A Sikh priest carries Sri Guru Granth Sahib, in Amritsar on July 24. ANI

of public order, decency or morality.

A cartoon, a novel, a documentary, a stray remark on social media: all can be made to fit the language of "insult" without any accompanying threat of actual disorder, and Indian criminal procedure allows a First Information Report to be lodged, and an accused to be arrested, well before any court examines whether the constitutionally required "deliberate and malicious intent" was in fact present. The chilling effect happens at the point of complaint, not at the point of conviction.

The Supreme Court has, in a neighbouring context, already endorsed exactly this objection. In *Shreya Singhal versus Union of India* in 2015, it struck down Section 66A of the Information Technology Act in its entirety, holding that criminalising online messages using undefined terms such as "offensive" and "menacing" left the provision impermissibly vague, invited arbitrary enforcement, and chilled protected speech in violation of Article 19(1)(a). Section 295A and its BNS successor rest on terms no more precise, "outrage," "insult," "religious feelings", policed after the fact by whichever officer happens to receive the complaint, yet the court has never brought the *Shreya Singhal* reasoning to bear on the provision whose own constitutionality it settled, without revisiting it since *Ramji Lal Modi* almost sixty years earlier. The inconsistency reads as reluctance rather than principle: it is easier to strike down a recent statute governing an unfamiliar medium than to unsettle an eighty-year-old precedent with a long and emotionally fraught

history behind it.

The Punjab context

Set against Punjab's law specifically, the contradiction sharpens into several distinct legal problems. The first concerns equality. By protecting only the Guru Granth Sahib and no other scripture, the 2026 Act revives the very objection that sank the 2016 attempt: a provision drawing a line between one community's sacred text and every other's needs an "intelligible differentia" bearing a "rational nexus" to its stated purpose of communal harmony, the test the Supreme Court set out in *State of West Bengal versus Anwar Ali Sarkar*, and it is difficult to see how singling out one faith serves a purpose framed in terms of all of them.

This is not merely a doctrinal prediction. In May 2026, the Anglican Church of India, through its Amritsar bishop, petitioned the Punjab and Haryana High Court arguing that the Act creates a religion-specific penal regime that violates the constitutional guarantee of equality before law, and sought both the quashing of the Act and a stay on its implementation.

The Bench's response points to an underappreciated wrinkle in the equality argument itself: it reportedly questioned how a church whose own scripture the Act does not touch could claim to be aggrieved by it at all, a question that inadvertently demonstrates the very defect being alleged, since a law can discriminate in structure while leaving those it excludes without the conventional standing to challenge it. The

petition remains pending.

The second is a matter of proportionality. The Act's mandatory minimum sentence, which under its most serious provisions can extend to life imprisonment and leaves no room for a judge to calibrate punishment to the facts of a given case, sits awkwardly beside *Mithu versus State of Punjab*, in which the Supreme Court struck down a different mandatory sentencing provision precisely because it stripped courts of discretion and so failed the test of a "just, fair and reasonable" procedure that *Maneka Gandhi versus Union of India* had read into Article 21; that the earlier case also happened to arise out of Punjab makes the parallel almost too neat. The third goes to federal competence. Criminal law sits on the Concurrent List, and Article 254 provides that a State law repugnant to a central enactment on the same subject, such as the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita's own provisions on sacrilege and on outraging religious feeling, is void to that extent unless it has received Presidential assent under Article 254(2). Punjab avoided that requirement in 2026 by amending a pre-existing, ostensibly ceremonial state statute rather than the BNS directly, an approach now under challenge in the Punjab and Haryana High Court on precisely the ground that a life sentence for the same underlying wrong cannot dodge central scrutiny merely by changing which statute book it sits in. Each of these is a distinct constitutional infirmity, quite apart from the broader secularism argument above, and Punjab's law arguably carries all three at once. (Second in a three-part series)



FROM THE ARCHIVES

Know your English

S. Upendran

Why do people say that there is a 'bug' in the computer? (T. Ravindran, Vellore)

Whenever something goes wrong with one's computer, people generally say that it has a "bug".

How did the word "bug" become associated with computers? Well, believe it or not, the original "debugging" process involved the removal of a bug from a computer! The story goes that a computer at the Naval Surface Warfare Center in Dahlgren, Virginia, malfunctioned. Grace Hopper, a Naval Officer, was asked to determine what was wrong with it. She opened up the computer and started checking the circuits. What do you think she found? She found a moth stuck in one of the circuits. When she removed the insect, the computer started working again. This incident took place in 1945; since then whenever something goes wrong with a computer, people say there is a bug in it. This is the story that most people tell as to why the word "bug" has come to be associated with computers. But the fact is, the word "bug" has been used to mean "defect" for several centuries - long before computers came into being! By the way, the moth that Grace Hopper removed is displayed at the Smithsonian Museum of American History in Washington, DC.

What is the meaning and origin of the expression "rule of thumb"? (N. Saraswathi, Bangalore)

The next time you watch your mother or grandmother cook, pay close attention to the manner in which she measures the salt to put in the sambar or curry. Does she measure it at all? They seem to have a rough idea of how much salt to put in; this instinct that they have is based on experience. And that is what the expression "rule of thumb" means. It's a rough method of calculation based on experience. Your calculations may not be exact, but you will come up with an approximately correct answer.

There are several explanations as to the origin of this expression. The standard explanation is that whenever we want to measure something roughly, we invariably use the thumb to do it. The first joint of the thumb in the case of most adults is roughly one inch long. Many people use this approximation to measure other objects. This is what we mean by "rule of thumb". This makes a lot of sense; after all, we have all done this some time or the other. But an explanation which is much more popular is the following. People contend that there was a Common Law in England, which stipulated that when beating one's wife, the stick used should not be broader than one's thumb! This rule was only for wife beating - the rule of thumb did not apply when beating one's child or husband! Many scholars have discarded this wife-beating theory because they have been unable to find any mention of such a rule in Law books.

How is the word "sleuth" pronounced? (D. Sundaramoorthy, Chennai)

The "eu" is pronounced like the "oo" in "cool", "pool", and "fool", while the final "th" is like the "th" in "thank", "think", and "through". In other words, sleuth rhymes with "tooth", "booth", and "truth". Any idea who or what a "sleuth" is? Well, a sleuth is a detective. The word is considered to be rather old-fashioned. Published in *The Hindu* on September 9, 2001

Word of the day

Aspersions: a disparaging remark

Synonyms: criticism, attack, contempt, insult

Usage: She was angry at the aspersions made about her work.

Pronunciation: newsth.live/aspersions

International Phonetic Alphabet: /əˈspɜːʃən/

For feedback and suggestions for Text & Context, please write to letters@thehindu.co.in with the subject 'Text & Context'

THE DAILY QUIZ

Three years ago, Spain defeated England, 1-0, to win the country's first Women's World Cup. Here is a quiz to test your knowledge of the FIFA Women's World Cup

Sindhu Nagaraj

QUESTION 1
When was the competition first held?

QUESTION 2
Where was the inaugural tournament held?

QUESTION 3
Which country has won the tournament the maximum number of times?

QUESTION 4
Which country is scheduled to host the 2027 edition?

QUESTION 5
Starting from which year will the number of finalists once again increase from 32 to 48?



Visual Question: In this image, which team won the 2019 FIFA Women's World Cup title?

Questions and Answers to the previous day's daily quiz: 1. This town, on National Highway 1, is often called the Gateway to Ladakh and has become a tourist spot because of its Kargil War association. Name it. **Ans:** Dras

2. This man, who partly grew up in Turkey, sent plane loads of relief to India following the Gujarat earthquake, just two years after the Kargil War for which he was the architect. He was sentenced to death in his country for subverting the Constitution. Name him. **Ans:** Pervez Musharraf

3. This Army officer, posthumously awarded the Param Vir Chakra, was killed at point 4875 during the Kargil War.

He was played by Siddharth Malhotra in the 2021 film *Shershaah*. Name him. **Ans:** Captain Vikram Batra

4. This elite squadron that executed Operation Safed Sagar was also involved in executing Operation Sindoor in 2025. Name them. **Ans:** Golden Arrows

5. What was the military operation to clear out the Kargil sector called? **Ans:** Operation Vijay

Visual: Indian Prime Minister Atal Bihari Vajpayee is seen in this photo with Pakistani Prime Minister Nawaz Sharif in 1999 just months before the Kargil war broke out. What was the name of the peace agreement that they signed? **Ans:** Lahore Declaration

Early Birds: Sitaram Saharay | Sukdev Shet | Dodo Jayaditya | Sumana Dutta | Arun Kumar Singh

Please send in your answers to dailyquiz@thehindu.co.in



From Page One

NTA reforms should have continuity: SC

The reforms in testing agency should focus on building an "institutional memory", the Supreme Court said.

It should not be that a committee proposes a set of reforms which are implemented in one exam, after which senior NTA officers are shifted out and the reforms are undone in the next exam, Justice Narasimha said. There ought to be meaningful continuity in resolving systemic problems within the NTA, the court said.

The court pointed out to how the Union Public Service Commission has been conducting public exams without a hitch.

"Life changes with every exam. The system changes with every exam. There are new technological challenges. How are you facing them? Have you developed the necessary infrastructure? Have you the software systems required in place?" Justice Narasimha asked Solicitor-General Tushar Mehta, appearing for the Union government and the NTA.

The court referred to an August 4 affidavit filed by the Union government, listing several senior appointments to be made to the NTA.

Mr. Mehta agreed to the need for a "permanent mechanism" to introduce reforms and maintain their continuity as keepers of the NTA's institutional memory. He suggested that Mr. Radhakrishnan could be requested to be made a member of the Nilekani task force.

Justice Narasimha asked the Union government to first file an affidavit explaining what it had done to implement the nuanced guidelines recommended by the Radhakrishnan Committee.

The government, in its affidavit, hailed the Public Examinations (Prevention of Unfair Means) Act of 2026 and the forming of the task force under Mr. Nilekani as "landmark measures" against future paper leaks.

Any structural change in the design of the NEET-UG would be undertaken only in consultation with and the concurrence of the Union Health Ministry and the National Medical Commission, the government said. The government said it was creating an "institutional memory" bank drawn from experiences after every public examination. A formal "Learnings Note" is prepared recording the challenges encountered, the actions taken and the practices to be carried forward.

Kolkata blaze kills 9; at least 5 from Bangladesh

Chief Minister Suvenudh Adhikari said the tragedy was a "grim reminder of the legacy of negligence left behind by the previous regime". He said the government was working tirelessly to "undo the damage of that era and to enforce the safety standards that should have been in place all along".

Several West Bengal Ministers, including Fire and Emergency Services Minister Kaushik Chowdhury and Urban Development Minister Agnimitra Paul, reached the site early in the morning. Ms. Paul said that 10 guesthouses were operating from the building. She blamed the previous Trinamool Congress government for issuing licences for such installations, adding that her government has completed only 100 days in office.

Prime Minister Narendra Modi said he was "extremely pained" to learn about the loss of lives. "My condolences to those who have lost their loved ones in this tragedy. May the injured recover at the earliest. The local administration is assisting those who are affected," he said in a post on X.

The Bangladesh Deputy High Commission in Kolkata issued a helpline -- +880171291266 (WhatsApp) and +919274821452 -- for families of the injured and the dead. An official said the commission is open round-the-clock and bodies will be repatriated to Bangladesh once the identities of the deceased are confirmed. Of the five Bangladeshi victims identified, four are from a family that had come from Kushtia.

NMC proposes single licence for doctors to practise across India

Bindu Shajan Perappadan
NEW DELHI

The National Medical Commission (NMC) has proposed a registration system under which a medical practitioner, once registered with a State Medical Council and allotted a Unique Identification (UID) number in the National Medical Register, would be eligible to practise across India without obtaining fresh registration or a licence in another State.

The proposal is part of the draft Registration of Medical Practitioners and Licence to Practice Medicine (Amendment) Regulations, 2026, notified by the NMC on August 11. The

NMC has invited objections and suggestions for 30 days from the date of notification.

Under the proposed system the State Medical Council would continue to scrutinise applications and grant registration and the licence for doctors to practise, but the approval would be reflected in both the State Medical Register and the National Medical Register.

The draft rules seek to amend the 2023 regulations governing registration and licensing of doctors, routing the process through a unified registration portal of the NMC's Ethics and Medical Registration Board.

RJD leaders detained amid protest against paper leaks

Tejashwi Yadav, Misa Bharti were among those detained; protesters carry dummy AK-47 guns in symbolic protest against 'firing' on protesters at Siwan in Bihar; delegation submits memorandum

Amarnath Tewary
PATNA

Rashtriya Janata Dal (RJD) leaders Tejashwi Yadav and Misa Bharti were among those detained by the police on Wednesday when the party took out a protest march to the Lok Bhawan in Patna over issues such as question paper leaks, unemployment, and the alleged firing on student protesters in Siwan last month.

The police stopped the march before it reached its destination, and later detained the party leaders, who were taken to the Secretariat Police Station. From there, a party delegation went to submit a memorandum to the Bihar Governor, Lieutenant-General Syed Ata Hasnain (retd).

Leaders of the ruling National Democratic Alliance (NDA) took a swipe at Mr. Yadav, who is the Leader of Opposition in the Bihar Assembly, quipping that "he woke up to support students after 20 days" and terming the protest a "save



RJD leader Tejashwi Yadav being detained by the police during a march towards Lok Bhawan in Patna on Wednesday. ANI

Tejashwi Yadav march".

The march began at the J.P. Roundabout near Gandhi Maidan and headed towards the Lok Bhawan. The police first tried to stop the march at the Dak Bungalow crossing, but protesters removed or jumped over barricades. When they got to the Income-Tax roundabout, the police used water cannons to stop them, before detaining Mr. Yadav, Ms. Bharti, and others.

Later, RJD leader Abdul Bari Siddiqui led a delegation to meet the Governor to submit their memorandum.

"Since Governor sahab was not present, we submitted our memorandum on behalf of our leader, Tejashwi Yadav, to the principal secretary of the Governor," Mr. Siddiqui said.

During the march, many of the protesters carried the Tricolour, while some also carried dummy AK-47 guns in a symbolic rebuke of the alleged firing on student protesters in Siwan on July 25. "These are symbolic, toy guns to remind the government about the firing incident of Siwan," a protester said.

A large number of policemen were deployed at various crossings in Patna.

Speaking to reporters after being detained, Mr. Yadav said, "The government is afraid of the youth, but the RJD will continue to raise issues concerning students and unemployment. No government is permanent; every government has to go one day... We are not afraid to go to jail... We will keep fighting for the rights of the students." He called for maintaining transparency in examinations and for putting a stop to "recurring paper leaks" and unemployment.

His elder sister and MP Misa Bharti brought up the alleged firing in Siwan. "The students of Bihar are ready to go to jail and continue their protest until the officer responsible for giving the order to the Siwan policeman to fire upon protesting students with an AK-47 is suspended," she said.

BJP leader Dilip Jaiswal said, "It was nothing but a desperate attempt to save Tejashwi Yadav's declining political future..."

Spurious liquor kills 4 in 'dry' Gujarat; 4 bootleggers caught

Press Trust of India
BHAVNAGAR (GUJARAT)

Four persons died and 18 have been hospitalised, eight of them in critical condition, after consuming spurious liquor in Bhavnagar district of Gujarat, officials said on Wednesday.

Four bootleggers have been detained in this connection, they said, adding that the victims had consumed counterfeit liquor of a popular Indian-made foreign liquor (IMFL) brand. Gujarat is a 'dry' State where manufacturing, sale, and consumption of alcohol are banned.

Bhavnagar Collector Manish Kumar said the district administration received information around 6 p.m. on Tuesday about a group of five friends falling ill after consuming illicit liquor during a party in Kharakdi village in the Ghogha taluka of the district.

"People from other villages and areas within Bhavnagar city have also been affected. In total, 22 people are impacted. While four persons have died, 18 are currently undergoing treatment," he added.

Victims consumed counterfeit liquor of an Indian-made foreign liquor brand, say officials

told reporters.

He also appealed to all those in the affected areas who consumed IMFL of a particular brand in the last four days to get themselves examined at the nearest hospital.

"Bootleggers from Varde and other police station areas in the city have been detained," Superintendent of Police (SP) Nitesh Pandey said.

"Preliminary investigation suggests that these bottles were supplied from Madhya Pradesh, and further investigation is underway," he said.

"Many bottles of the same brand have been seized and efforts are under way to apprehend other bootleggers involved in the supply of spurious liquor," the official said. "A team from the Forensic Science Laboratory (FSL) was also involved in the scientific investigation," he added.

SC gives ultimatum to Odisha government on remission plea of convict in Staines' murder

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

The Supreme Court on Wednesday criticised the Odisha government for delaying a decision on the remission plea filed by Rabin Kumar Pal alias Dara Singh, who is serving a life sentence in the triple murder of Australian missionary Graham Staines and his two young sons in January 1999.

Staines and his sons, aged six and 10, were sleeping in their vehicle parked outside a church when a mob set fire to the car. The mob prevented the father and sons from getting out of the burning vehicle.

A Bench headed by Justice Manoj Misra cautioned



The court has listed the case for hearing on September 2.

the State government that procrastination would only lead to the Supreme Court taking over and deciding the remission petition.

"If you do not decide, we will... We are not concerned how you are communicating. Just take a decision. We will not tolerate this avoiding taking a decision," Justice Misra addressed the State counsel.

Singh has sought remission on the ground that the Odisha Remission Rules allow it after 25 years of the sentence. He said he had already served 26 years. Singh filed his remission petition in 2024, but the State was yet to decide.

The Bench orally said it would give the State a final opportunity to take a call on the remission plea.

"The matter was adjourned for the Sentence Review Board to take a decision. Today, the counsel for the State has placed before us a letter of the prison authorities wherein they say certain documents crucial to taking the decision are yet to be received," the court noted. It listed the case for September 2.

JPSC-JSSC Reform Manch calls off stir after Jharkhand govt. scraps 22 recruitment exams

Amit Bhelari
PATNA

The JPSC-JSSC Reform Manch on Wednesday announced the suspension of its agitation for two months following the Jharkhand government's notification on the cancellation of 22 recruitment examinations.

The State government late on Tuesday notified the cancellations citing complaints of irregularities and "facts brought before the government during the CID investigation".

Besides these, six examinations have been postponed, followed by a CID probe. Another 17 examinations will be investigated by the agency, taking the number of exams under

Another 17 exams will be investigated by the CID, taking the number of exams under lens to 23

the scanner to 23.

The JPSC-JSSC Manch clarified that "the movement has not been terminated". "If our remaining demands are not met within two months, we will resume the movement..." they said.

The cancelled exams include those conducted by the Jharkhand Public Service Commission (JPSC) and the TSR Data Processing Private Limited (TDPL) since 2014. The 11th to 13th JPSC exams, as well as the CDPO and JSSC-CGL exam-

inations were cancelled.

The State government said it will urge the High Court to constitute a fast-track court for the trial of cases regarding irregularities in JPSC and JSSC.

It also said that a committee formed to suggest reforms in the conduct of examinations in the State, which was announced on Monday, will submit its report within two months.

"An Internal Monitoring Cell will be constituted within JPSC/JSSC and a committee will be constituted under the chairmanship of Amitabh Kaushal (IAS)," it added.

In a related development, the successful candidates of JSSC-CGL continued their protest for the third consecutive day.

Court issues orders for arrest warrant against Mahua

Senjuti Sengupta
KOLKATA

A court in West Bengal's Nadia district on Wednesday directed the issuance of an arrest warrant against the Trinamool Congress MP Mahua Moitra for allegedly making statements that hurt religious sentiments.

"Five women made a petition on June 12 that Ms. Moitra made a derogatory statement that hurt the sentiments of the Hindu community. Subsequently, she did not appear in the court despite being summoned multiple times. As per the court's order [of Wednesday], we have officially issued it [an arrest warrant] today," Krishnanagar Superintendent of Police Anil V. said.

Ms. Moitra's counsel had expressed apprehension to the court that the MP might be heckled outside the court premises if she appeared.

Rajnath, Japanese Defence Minister to hold talks today

Saurabh Trivedi
NEW DELHI

Defence Minister Rajnath Singh will hold a bilateral meeting with his Japanese counterpart, Shinjiro Koizumi, in New Delhi on Thursday, with the two sides expected to discuss ways to further strengthen defence and security cooperation and enhance strategic trust in the Indo-Pacific.

According to the Ministry of Defence, the Ministers are expected to exchange views on deeper maritime security cooperation and closer collaboration in defence equipment and technology under the "Make in India" framework, particularly following Japan's revision of its Three Principles on Transfer of Defence Equipment and Technology.

The meeting is also expected to provide an opportunity to identify new areas of collaboration and prepare a road map for ad-



Shinjiro Koizumi during a visit to the Navy's Western Command in Mumbai. @MODJAPAN_EN

vancing bilateral defence and security cooperation, with both countries sharing a vision of a free, open, resilient and prosperous Indo-Pacific.

Mr. Koizumi, on his maiden visit to India, visited the Western Naval Command in Mumbai on Wednesday. He held discussions with the Chief of the Naval Staff, Admiral Krishna Swaminathan, and Flag Officer Commanding-in-Chief, Western Naval Command, Vice-Admiral Sanjay

Vatsayan. He also visited the indigenously built guided-missile destroyer *INS Chennai*.

The two-day visit underscores the growing momentum in India-Japan defence ties and comes weeks after Japanese Prime Minister Sanae Takaichi's visit to New Delhi for the Annual Summit with Prime Minister Narendra Modi, where the two sides agreed to deepen defence and security cooperation.

Cabinet approves 4 railway projects worth ₹9,450 crore

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

The Cabinet Committee on Economic Affairs, chaired by Prime Minister Narendra Modi, on Wednesday approved four projects of the Ministry of Railways with a total estimated cost of ₹9,450 crore.

Expected to be completed by 2030-31, the projects are spread across eight districts in West Bengal, Odisha, Tamil Nadu and Andhra Pradesh and will increase track capacity by about 410 km.

The projects include the 173-km fourth line between Kharagpur and Bhadrak (Kantail) in West Bengal and Odisha; the 75-km fourth line between Bhadrak and Haridaspur in Odisha; the 90-km third and fourth lines between Gummidipundi and Gudur in Andhra Pradesh and Tamil Nadu; and the 72-km third and fourth lines between

Cuttack and Paradeep (Badabandha) in Odisha.

The increased line capacity is expected to enhance mobility, operational efficiency and service reliability while easing congestion on the routes.

The projects have been planned under the PM-Gati Shakti National Master Plan, with a focus on enhancing multimodal connectivity and logistical efficiency through integrated planning and stakeholder consultations.

The projects are expected to provide improved connectivity for the movement of people, goods, and services and connect approximately 6,448 villages with a combined population of about 60 lakhs, a Railway Ministry spokesperson stated.

The enhanced capacity will improve connectivity to several prominent tourist destinations across the country.

Cong. to launch campaign against Ram Temple 'theft', step up student outreach

Party backs two-stanza *Vande Mataram*; it will expand *Chhatron Ki Goonj* campaign to 800 cities, towns; Rahul seeks report on reforms needed in education system from Cong. CMs; CWC discusses 'Chinese incursions' in Arunachal Pradesh, E20 fuel issue, demands Lok Sabha freeze at 543 seats

Sandeep Phukan
NEW DELHI

The Congress Working Committee (CWC) on Wednesday decided to expand its student outreach programme, *Chhatron Ki Goonj*, to around 800 cities and towns, while announcing a nationwide campaign over the alleged "chanda chori" (theft of donations) at the Ram Temple in Ayodhya.

"This is not a theft at Ram Mandir alone but *ghar ghar chori*," Congress general secretary (organisation) K.C. Venugopal said at a media briefing after a marathon four-hour meeting. Taking a leaf out of the BJP's playbook, Mr. Venugopal argued that as almost every believer donated towards the construction of the Ram temple, "it is like stealing from every home".

Congress leader Rahul Gandhi, who would be the student interaction programme, also asked Chief Ministers of Congress-ruled States to prepare a report on reforms needed in their education systems and submit it to Congress



Firming up strategy: Congress leaders Mallikarjun Kharge, Sonia Gandhi, Rahul Gandhi and others at the Congress Working Committee meeting in New Delhi on Wednesday. SUSHIL KUMAR VERMA

president Mallikarjun Kharge within a month.

The Hindu has learnt that Mr. Gandhi, in the closed-door interaction, chided his colleagues for not meeting enough students or going to Jantar Mantar to express solidarity during the NEET paper leak protests. "I have met more students than any of you," he is learnt to have said. He said a straw poll conducted by the Congress's student and youth wings showed that a majority of students backed the Congress and its leadership for change. Mr. Gandhi made it clear that he would stand with the stu-

dents, "come what may".

Mr. Kharge, in his opening remarks, accused the Narendra Modi government of "destroying" the future of students and called for a comprehensive "Education-to-Employment Road map" for the youth. Former Chief Minister Charanjit Singh Channi, a CWC member, skipped the meeting amid infighting in the Punjab Congress.

Issues identified

The CWC decided to launch a nationwide campaign over the alleged theft of donations at the Ram Mandir in Ayodhya, while reiterating its demand for a

Supreme Court-supervised probe and an audit of the temple trust's accounts.

It asserted that the Lok Sabha's strength should remain frozen at 543 seats, with the existing State-wise allocation retained for 25 years, and that one-third women's reservation should be implemented from the 2029 elections.

It reaffirmed that Congress functions would feature only the first two stanzas of *Vande Mataram*, in line with the 1937 AICC resolution. It demanded an apology from Prime Minister Narendra Modi over the "purification ritual" at the Haldwani ground where

Mr. Kharge had addressed a rally. The resolution flagged reports of Chinese incursions in Arunachal Pradesh and questioned the government's silence, besides raising concerns over E20 petrol's mileage, compatibility and loss of consumer choice.

The CWC resolution said the youth were facing "disappointment and betrayal" under the Modi government, citing paper leaks, unemployment, and alleged repression of student movements. "Over the past decade, paper leaks have assumed epidemic proportions, with at least 152 cases of paper leaks reported since 2014," the resolution said.

The CWC condemned what it called "arbitrary and brutal repression" of student movements, alleging the use of tear gas, pellet guns and electric shock batons and accusing the Prime Minister and Home Minister of avoiding Parliament on the issue.

Mr. Gandhi said the protests had rattled Mr. Modi and described the government's response as a sign of weakness. "Prime Minister is on his knees

and the people who put him there are looking for his replacement," he is learnt to have said. He said Mr. Modi's Independence Day speech looked like it came "from a man who has been psychologically defeated".

Mr. Kharge, without naming anyone, expressed concern over three or four party leaders who frequently appeared on television but did not always reflect the party line. Mr. Gandhi subsequently asked the party's social media head, Supriya Shrinani, to send him regular reports on which party leaders were or were not amplifying Mr. Kharge's messages.

The *Vande Mataram* issue was discussed in detail, with senior leaders Anand Sharma, Tariq Anwar, and Digvijay Singh arguing that the Congress should adhere to the 1937 AICC resolution. Mr. Kharge read out an order of President Rajendra Prasad to reinforce the party's position, reiterating that the first two stanzas were adopted for singing at its functions following consultations with Rabindranath Tagore.

Census 2027 has a nefarious purpose, says Jairam Ramesh

Vijaita Singh
NEW DELHI



Jairam Ramesh

Congress general secretary Jairam Ramesh on Wednesday alleged that Census 2027 had a "deeper nefarious purpose", citing the inclusion of what he described as unprecedented questions on religion, date of birth and the birthplace of respondents' parents.

He raised concerns over the Census questionnaire, alleging that the methodology for collecting caste data is "deliberately flawed".

He was responding to a *The Hindu* report published on August 18 that the questionnaire for the Population Enumeration phase of Census 2027 has gone live in Ladakh and snow-bound areas of three other States ahead of the rest of the country. The questionnaire seeks information on religion, date of birth and place of birth, up to the village level, of both the father and the mother of respondents.

While members of Scheduled Caste and Scheduled Tribes can choose their caste or tribe from a predetermined drop-down menu, other respondents will have to type their caste name in an open field.

In a post on X, Mr. Ra-

mesh said the approach to gathering caste-related information could undermine the credibility of the data collected. "The methodology of asking questions on caste in Census 2027 is deliberately flawed," he said.

Flags micro questions

He pointed to what he described as unprecedented questions seeking details related to religion and date of birth. According to him, such "micro questions" have not featured in previous Census exercises.

Mr. Ramesh also noted that Census data are traditionally protected by confidentiality provisions and argued that the expanded scope of data collection raises concerns about the government's intentions. "Census is confidential. Clearly, Census 2027 has a deeper nefarious purpose," he alleged.

Get seed fund usage details from NTA, House panel tells Education Ministry

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

The Public Accounts Committee (PAC) of Parliament on Wednesday directed the Ministry of Education to ensure that the National Testing Agency (NTA) submits pending utilisation certificates for ₹10 crore out of the ₹25 crore seed funding it received from the government in 2017.

The issue came up during the PAC's examination of a Comptroller and Auditor General (CAG) report on outstanding utilisation certificates. The committee, headed by senior Con-



K.C. Venugopal-led panel was examining a report on pending utilisation certificates. FILE PHOTO

gress leader K.C. Venugopal, asked the Ministry to ensure that the pending certificates are furnished within 60 days.

Under government

rules, utilisation certificates are required to be submitted within 12 months of the close of the financial year in the case of non-recurring grants. The certificates enable the government to verify that public funds have been spent on purposes for which they were sanctioned.

One-time assistance

The NTA, which was approved by the Union Cabinet in November 2017 as an autonomous and self-financing body, received a one-time financial assistance of ₹25 crore from the Centre at the time of its

creation. According to the CAG report, the certificates for ₹10 crore from this grant remain pending for the financial year 2018-19.

Officials from the Ministries of Finance and Education were present before the committee. Sources said Mr. Venugopal and others questioned officials about the lapse and wanted to know if any examination-related activities had been affected as a result.

They also sought details of safeguards in place to ensure that deficiencies in financial management do not affect the conduct of examinations.

J&K an 'important part of India'; will re-evaluate travel advisory: U.S. envoy

Peerzada Ashiq
SRINAGAR

On his maiden visit to Jammu and Kashmir, Sergio Gor, U.S. Ambassador to India and Special Envoy to South and Central Asia, on Wednesday praised the Centre and Chief Minister Omar Abdullah for their efforts to "keep India's important place safe".

"J&K is an important part of India and it's an incredibly beautiful place. I am thrilled to see this place. Delhi and the Chief Minister have made incredible steps to keep this place safe. We will have some fol-



Boosting ties: U.S. Ambassador Sergio Gor with Jammu & Kashmir Chief Minister Omar Abdullah. X/@USAMBINDIA

low-ups to Washington and Delhi," Mr. Gor said after meeting Mr. Abdullah at the latter's residence here. Referring to J&K as "an important part of India" is a departure from the past,

when Kashmir was referred to as "an unresolved issue between India and Pakistan". Mr. Gor hinted at re-evaluating the travel advisory for J&K, which remains in the "Level 4 - Do

not travel" category. "We will be looking at travel warnings. It should be downgraded. It [J&K] is a beautiful area and a lot of Americans want to come here," he said.

Mr. Abdullah said that the meeting was "good opportunity to discuss relations between two countries and what the U.S. can do with J&K". "There are some legacy issues which over time we will be working to resolve," he added.

Pakistan summoned U.S. Chargé d'Affaires Natalie Baker and lodged a "strong demarche" over remarks by Mr. Gor.

Rahul backs protest against river linking project

Press Trust of India
NEW DELHI

Expressing support for the tribals staging a 'satyagrah' against the Ken-Betwa river-linking project, Congress leader Rahul Gandhi on Wednesday said he stands with them in this struggle and will visit the site to exert pressure on the government.

He shared on X a video of his recent meeting with a group of tribals affected by the project.

"The problems, demands, struggles, and personal ordeals of the tribal brothers and sisters who are carrying out a satyagrah against the Ken-Betwa project - their own account. For years, these residents of Bundelkhand have been enduring injustice and oppression solely for their rights; they deserve respect and support," Mr. Gandhi said.

In the video, a tribal representative is heard saying that the project would affect 21 tribal-dominated villages. They urged Mr. Gandhi to raise the issue and join the movement.

Odisha Police
Office of the D.G. & I.G. of Police, Odisha, Kataka
Tel.: 0671-2304001, Website: police.odisha.gov.in, Email: adgcs-odisha@gov.in
RFP No. 134/PF/2026 for providing Naval Expert Advisory-2026-27 Date: 19.08.2026
Online Bids through e-Tender Portal <https://tenders.odisha.gov.in> are invited from the eligible bidders for Selection of a Consultancy firm for establishing the technical Assistance and support Unit (TASU) for providing Naval Experts Advisory for Odisha Coastal security Wing, Odisha Police during the CPY 2026-27 as per the schedule mentioned below.

Sl.No.	Name of Item	Approximate quantity
1	13-RFP-TASU for providing Naval Expert Advisory-2026-27	Different Items
SL No.	Particulars	Details
2	Method of Selection & Proposal Validity	Quality cum Cost Based Selection (QCBS) & 120 Day's proposal validity
3	Date of Issue of RFP	19.08.2026
4	Deadline for Submission of Pre-Proposal / Pre-Bid Queries	28.08.2026
5	Pre-Bid Meeting	A Pre-Bid Meeting will be informed later based on the queries submitted by bidder (Online Link shall be shared based on the request received from bidder on E-Mail id: adgcs-odisha@gov.in)
7	Proposal Submission Due Date	10.09.2026 i.e. 04.30 PM https://tenders.odisha.gov.in/
8	Date of opening of Technical Proposal	11.09.2026
16	RFP can be downloaded from	https://police.odisha.gov.in/ ; https://tenders.odisha.gov.in

The bid document with all information relating to the bidding process including cost of bid document, Prequalification criteria and terms & conditions are available in the websites: <https://tenders.odisha.gov.in/>. The Authority reserves the right to accept / reject any part thereof or all the bids without assigning any reason therefor.
A.I.G. of Police (Provisioning), Odisha, Kataka,
(Tender Calling Authority)
CPFR-09011020911026-270024

ICMR-NIVCR
INDIAN COUNCIL OF MEDICAL RESEARCH
NATIONAL INSTITUTE FOR VECTOR CONTROL RESEARCH
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INDIRA NAGAR, MEDICAL COMPLEX
PUDUCHERRY- 605 006
Date: 20.06.2026
Advertisement No.01/ICMR-NIVCR/2026-27
Applications are invited upto 04.09.2026 to fill up of four posts of Young Professional III on contractual basis at ICMR-National Institute for Vector Control Research (ICMR-NIVCR), Puducherry;
For educational qualification and other information, please visit the Institute's website <https://ivrc.icmr.org.in> and ICMR website <https://icmr.gov.in>. Application form may be downloaded from the websites and sent with required copies of certificates to the Director, ICMR-NIVCR, Medical Complex, Indira Nagar, Puducherry - 605 006.
Director

Central Mine Planning and Design Institute Limited
(A Subsidiary of Coal India Limited)
Gondwana Place, Kankar Road, Ranchi - 834008, Jharkhand, India
NOTICE
"All the tenders issued by CIL and its Subsidiaries for procurement of Goods, Works and Services are available on websites of Coal India Ltd. www.coalindia.in / respective Subsidiary Company (CMPDI, www.cmpdi.co.in), CIL e-procurement portal <https://coalindiatenders.nic.in> and Central Public Procurement portal <https://eprocure.gov.in>. In addition, procurement is also done through GeM Portal <https://gem.gov.in/>."

OFFICE OF THE EXECUTIVE ENGINEER PWD ON MANDALGARH
Email: ee@mandalgarh.pwd.odisha.gov.in
Circuit Office, Mandalgarh, Dist. Bhubaneswar
NB CODE- PWD0267A263
Short term Notice inviting Bid-12/2026-27
Bids for Contract for Construction of All Purpose Path Under Budget Amendment & Construction of Road under DMFT FY 2026-27 invited from interested bidders upto 24.08.2026 other particulars of the bid may be visited on the procurement portal (<http://tenders.odisha.gov.in>) or the state the approximate value of the procurement is Rs. 329.10 Lakh, NB CODE- PWD0267A263
UIN No. PWD0267W0810075
PWD0267W0810076
(S/L, Balmore)
Executive Engineer
PWD On Mandalgarh
Email: ee@mandalgarh.pwd.odisha.gov.in

कल्याण सिंह अति विशिष्ट कैंसर संस्थान
कैंसर रोग, रसायन विज्ञान, कैंसर-226002
(कैंसर रोग के अग्रणी केंद्र)
Website: www.cancersinstitute.edu.in Email: procurementservices.kssci@gmail.com
CAMC of Modular OT at KSSSCI
It is hereby informed that bid No. GEM/2026/B/788234 Dated: 18.08.2026 has been uploaded on GeM Portal under Customized AM/CM/IC for Pre-owned Products-CAMC of Modular Operation Theatre for CAMC of Modular OT at KSSSCI. All interested service providers/bidders are required to submit their bids on GeM Portal in accordance with the terms and conditions of the GeM bid documents. The Director reserves the right to accept or reject or all bids at any stage without assigning any reason therefor.
Note:
1. EMD Submitted through Insurance Surety, Account Payee, FDR, Banker's Cheque, Bank Guarantee will be accepted Physically and held valid for this Bid. However, UTR No. and a scanned copy must be uploaded with this GeM bid.
2. Site visit is mandatory.
The Tender documents are available on the website of the Institute www.cancersinstitute.edu.in.
Adv. No: KSSSCI-Tender-13/2026-27
DIRECTOR

TIRUMALA TIRUPATI DEVASTHANAMS - TIRUPATI
Office of the Chief Engineer
TENDER NOTICE
ADV No.26/03/CE/TID/2026-27 & NT No.297/SE/4/TID/2026-27 dt.17-08-2026
NAME OF WORK-1 Providing Facility management services (Operations & Comprehensive Museum Maintenance) of S.V. Museum, Tirumala for three years. Open Tender Type: Time for Completion: 36 months.
Note: For full details, log on to the Website <https://www.tirumala.org>.
TID-00210311/1/2026-PRI SEC(Am.No.156) Date:19-08-2026
EXECUTIVE OFFICER

ANDHRA PRADESH STATE AGRO INDUSTRIES DEVELOPMENT CORPORATION LIMITED
G1, G2, 011 PRIME HILL, GREYST, VADDESWARAM (VIL), MANGALGIRI, GUNTUR DT., 522002. Email: agpiddc@gm.com
Lr No: AgrosASWCDC-PKMSY-2.0 Phase-II/2024-25 Date: 19-08-2026
SHORT L1-TENDER THROUGH AP E-PROCUREMENT
Sealed tenders are invited from reputed manufacturers/importers for supply of Water Pumps, sprinkler sets, Chaff cutter, PP Equipment etc., under sub-sidy to the farmers under watershed project areas. The detailed Short L1-Tender Schedule including bid submission dates, eligibility criteria, document cost and other particulars are available in AP E-Procurement Portal. Interested Manufacturers/importers may download the L1-Tender schedule from D: 20-08-2026 onwards. Sd/- VICE CHAIRMAN and DIPR 5348 PPCL D: 19/08/2026
MANAGING DIRECTOR, APSACD Ltd.

Office of the Additional Chief Engineer (Project) PHED Ajmer
Qtr. No. II/2, PHED Colony, Vaishali Nagar, near RICO Watch Factory, Ph. No. 0145-2640265, email: acpengineer@gmail.com or acpengineer.phed@rajasthan.gov.in
S.No. P/ACE/Proj/AJ/AR-1M/2026-27/2554
CORRIGENDUM NO.8
NIB Code: PHED26A64H & UIN No. PHED26W01AR1856
In continuation to this office NIT No. 03/2025-26 issued vide letter No. 2436-2491 dated 11.02.2026. The following amendment is hereby notified:-
S. Description As per original NIT & Corrigendum As per this corrigendum
1. Date & time for downloading of tender document 13.02.2026 at 10:00 AM to 06.08.2026 up to 06:00 PM 13.02.2026 at 10:00 AM to 02.09.2026 up to 06:00 PM
2. Date & time for online submission of tender AM to up to 06.08.2026 at 6:00 PM Up to 02.09.2026 at 06:00 PM
3. Date & time of physical submission of tender, fee, RSL charges and EMD 07.08.2026 at 01:00 PM Up to 03.09.2026 at 01:00 PM
4. Date & time of opening of technical bid 07.08.2026 at 03:00 PM Up to 03.09.2026 at 03:00 PM
All other terms and conditions shall remain same as mentioned in tender document. (Kishan Kumar Agarwal)
Additional Chief Engineer (Project) PHED, Ajmer
DIPR/C/14381/2026
A NO-DE

IN BRIEF



34 children fall ill as detergent 'mixed' in Bihar school meal

At least 34 children – 17 each boys and girls – of Parsa Middle School in Nalanda district of Bihar fell ill after consuming midday meal on Tuesday, following allegations that detergent powder was served instead of salt “by mistake”. All the children were discharged from Biharsharif Sadar Hospital in Nalanda on Wednesday, while an FIR was registered in connection with the incident. Nalanda Civil Surgeon Jai Prakash Singh said it was a case of food poisoning. The children complained of a burning sensation in their throats and stomach pain after eating the meal, triggering panic on the school premises.

CBI arrests Haryana man on human trafficking charges

The Central Bureau of Investigation (CBI) has arrested a person allegedly associated with a network of agents involved in trafficking Indian nationals to scam compounds operating in Southeast Asia under the guise of lucrative overseas employment opportunities. The accused, identified as Ankita, a resident of Hisar in Haryana, was arrested in Delhi. The agency alleged that in 2025, he had sent at least four individuals from Hisar to scam compounds. “Some of them had to pay a significant amount to return home from these scam compounds or had to lure in a substitute to be able to return,” the agency said.

Independent advisor to I&B Ministry held in bribery case

The Central Bureau of Investigation (CBI) has arrested a Deputy Controller of Accounts, working as an independent financial advisor in the Union Ministry of Information and Broadcasting, in an alleged bribery case. The accused, identified as Sandeep Choudhary, was booked by the CBI on Tuesday, following a complaint alleging that he had demanded ₹15 lakh for the expeditious renewal of a contract. “After negotiation, the accused agreed to accept a bribe of ₹10 lakh from the complainant to expeditiously process the renewal file for the private company’s contract, which was pending before him,” the agency said.

RSS-linked academics in NCERT textbook panel

The NCERT has reconstituted the Textbook Development Team for Class 11 and Class 12 political science. At least four members of the team have direct or indirect links with the RSS. The team is led by academic and political analyst Sandeep Shastri. “Review of each of the textbooks will take place to oversee the integration of cross-cutting themes, such as cultural rootedness, Indian knowledge systems, inclusion, educational technology, assessment, etc.,” stated the notification from NCERT Director Dinesh Prasad Saklani. The team has been tasked with preparing the Class 11 textbook by this November and the Class 12 book by July 2027.

SC calls on students to school elders in waste management

Court questions notion that waste is a problem of sanitary workers alone; directs Education Dept. to include practical lessons for students; tells officials to engage with households, schools, colleges

Krishnadas Rajagopal
NEW DELHI

The Supreme Court has turned to Gen Z and Gen Alpha to “educate” their elders against the careless and excessive generation of everyday garbage, saying a minuscule number of sanitary workers across the country cannot be expected to deal with the solid waste produced by a population of 1.4 billion.

A Bench headed by Justice S.V.N. Bhatti said the “general feeling” across society was regrettably that “I am entitled to generate but not to cooperate and control the impact of solid waste management at the threshold.”

“The prevailing assumption that solid waste is a problem for sanitary workers alone, while the rest of the population remains passive generators, is neither legally correct nor practically sustainable, and is constitutionally unethical,” the court said in an order on August 18, but released on Wednesday. Continued complacency would lead to pandemic and endemic situations, it



A helping hand: NCC cadets clear litter as part of a beach cleaning drive recently held in Kochi. PTI

warned. “The volume and complexity of solid waste, i.e., biodegradable, non-biodegradable, hazardous, electronic and construction, have outgrown what any single class of workers can be expected to handle. The infrastructure needs a complete audit and upgrade to meet the extant standards of the Solid Waste Management (SWM) Rules, 2026,” it said.

In fact, the imbalance between the volume of the waste being generated and the infrastructure to collect it had so alarmed the top court on May 25 that it set up a committee of five Union Secretaries of the

Ministries of Housing and Urban Affairs; Environment, Forest and Climate Change; Jal Shakti; and Panchayati Raj and Rural Development and the Department of Drinking Water and Sanitation, along with the Member-Secretary of the Central Pollution Control Board, to monitor the situation.

But the Bench accepted the reality that law alone could not induce good civic behaviour. That had to come from within.

The court agreed with Additional Solicitor-General Aishwarya Bhati that to prevent an environmental disaster every stakeholder

had to cooperate, and the true power to implement the SWM Rules lay with the householders, local body officers and every direct and indirect contributor of waste.

Everybody’s job

“Every human being and their activities result in pollution, yet all contributors expect a minuscule percentage of sanitary workers to handle it. This perception shall be eradicated, and it shall be the responsibility of all contributors for waste management,” the court said. The court issued directions, including that District Collectors must engage with households and educational institutions.

The court directed the Department of School and Higher Education to integrate, with immediate effect, both theoretical and practical knowledge on solid waste management for students to train their family members, and also train teachers as trainers.

“An educated child is the most effective and least coercive instrument for educating a parent or a relative...,” the court said.

Census 2027: rights groups flag gaps in disability categories

Bindu Shajan Perappadan
NEW DELHI

Disability rights organisations and activists have raised concerns over the proposed classification of disabilities for enumeration in Census 2027, saying the nine-category framework does not adequately include several disabilities recognised under the Rights of Persons with Disabilities (RPwD) Act, 2016.

The National Platform for the Rights of the Disabled (NPd) said the proposed Census categories – seeing, hearing, speech, mobility, intellectual disability, mental illness, acid attack, chronic neurological disease and blood disorder – did not adequately reflect the 21 “specified disabilities” recognised under the RPwD Act.

New additions

The organisation pointed out that six of the proposed categories – seeing, hearing, speech, mobility, intellectual disability and mental illness – essentially carry forward the categories used in the 2011 Census, with “mental retardation” renamed “intellectual disability”. The additions are acid at-

tack, chronic neurological disease and blood disorder.

The NPd, citing information shared by the Politics & Disability Forum, said the proposed framework was particularly concerning in view of an assurance by Union Minister of State for Social Justice and Empowerment Ramdas Athawale that data on all 21 disabilities would be captured in the Census.

Poor representation

The RPwD Act recognises a wide range of conditions, including cerebral palsy, dwarfism, muscular dystrophy, specific learning disabilities, autism spectrum disorder and multiple sclerosis.

Activists said several of these conditions had not been distinctly represented in the proposed Census categories.

Autism spectrum disorder, specific learning disabilities, and dwarfism were among those they said risked being left out.

The organisations said such broad categorisation could affect the quality of data generated by enumerators and result in an undercount of specific disability groups.

In Gen Z outreach, Union Ministers set to visit universities

Press Trust of India
NEW DELHI

In a major outreach to the Gen Z in India, the Modi government plans to send one Union Minister to one university every day to engage with young people, discuss their concerns, and better understand their perspectives on issues facing the country.

Under the ‘One Day, One University’ programme, a Union Minister will visit an assigned university to interact with students, listen to their views on different subjects, and inform them about various government welfare schemes, particularly those for youth and students, sources aware of the initiative told PTI.

Ministers in charge Union Education Minister Pralhad Joshi and Union Youth Affairs and Sports

Minister Mansukh Mandavira have been given the responsibility to coordinate visits with the universities and Ministers.

“The plan also figured in a meeting of the Union Cabinet, chaired by Prime Minister Narendra Modi on Wednesday (August 19, 2026),” sources said.

According to the University Grants Commission, there are as many as 1,300 universities in the country, including 57 Central universities and 522 State universities, while others are either deemed-to-be or private universities.

The police crackdown on protesting students led to a massive backlash, with the Opposition disrupting proceedings during the monsoon session of Parliament. Amidst the protests, Dharmendra Pradhan had to resign as Education Minister on July 25, 2026.

‘Transmission constraints threaten India’s renewable energy expansion’

Jacob Koshy
NEW DELHI

Insufficient transmission lines have emerged as a major obstacle to India’s rapid expansion of renewable energy capacity, leading to many solar power projects being “curtailed” during daylight hours, rating agency ICRA said on Wednesday. Curtailment occurs when a power generator is forced to reduce or stop producing electricity due to oversupply and grid congestion.

Around 37% of renewable energy capacity at substations affected by curtailment in the northern, western, and southern regions operates under a Temporary General Network Access (T-GNA), and this capacity faces 30% to 50% curtailment during the day, ICRA said in a statement.

T-GNA is a short-term arrangement that allows a re-



Renewable energy will account for more than 35% of power generation by 2029-30.

newable energy project to use available capacity on the inter-State transmission system, typically for periods ranging from a single time block to about 11 months. Prolonged T-GNA use can affect a power supplier’s revenues. ICRA says projects operating under T-GNA are particularly vulnerable to curtailment, raising their operational costs.

In western India, where about 55% of the affected

capacity was under T-GNA, peak curtailment reached 8,617 MW as of August 6; the corresponding figure for the northern region was 5,573 MW.

Better infrastructure

Grishikumar Kadam, senior vice-president and group head of corporate ratings at ICRA, said at a press briefing that timely execution of intra-State and inter-State transmission infrastructure, along with greater storage capacity, would be critical to sustaining renewable energy additions. Apart from “transmission constraints”, the impediments included delays in firming Power Purchase Agreements, land acquisition, and distribution company finances.

The constraint comes even as India’s renewable energy pipeline remains substantial. ICRA said more than 150 GW of re-

newable projects were under construction as of June 30 this year. It estimates that renewable energy, including large hydro, will account for more than 35% of electricity generation by the financial year 2029-2030, compared with 22% in 2024-2025.

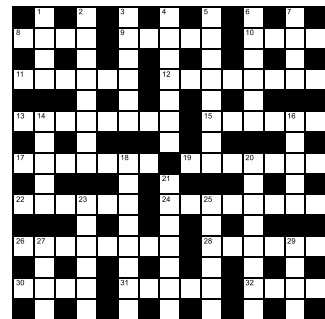
Grid adequacy is key

However, bids for new renewable energy projects have slowed sharply. After 40.6 GW was awarded in 2024-25, awards fell to 14.7 GW in 2025-26 and stood at 4.7 GW through August 10 this year.

ICRA also estimated that 40 GW to 45 GW of capacity with bids awarded remained without signed PPAs as of April 2026.

Mr. Kadam said the nature of new biddings also changing, with greater focus on firm and dispatchable renewable energy (FDRE) and round-the-clock (RTC) power.

THE CROSSWORD 14877

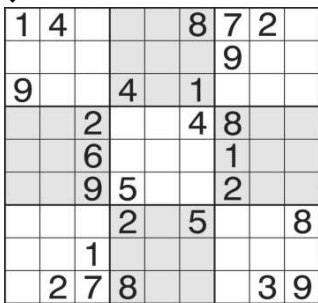


- Across
- 8 Legendary ship carried by Cargomaster (4)
 - 9 Strips for groups of musicians (5)
 - 10 Actor Guinness is back in Iceland (4)
 - 11 I left America in turmoil, producing photographic device (6)
 - 12 Metal vehicle with saint leaving stadium (8)
 - 13 Perhaps, something to break for breakfast, for example, with grand-son at Hades (8)

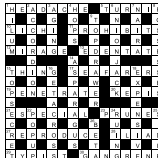
- 15 Mother and boy at top-class Indian metro (6)
- 17 Pirates organised beans (7)
- 19 Support Spanish river utilisation (7)
- 22 Wrongly harvest in absence of husband and go without food (6)
- 24 Sick! Cure and abuse? (3-5)
- 26 Rib and beans cooked in city (8)
- 28 Bird bearing small coins (6)
- 30 Irritated marines dropping madmen in Indian dress (4)
- 31 Aimlessly move one foot behind medic (5)
- 32 Bird from Bangkok... it enchants! (4)

- Down
- 1 Without distribution of notice, auctioneer dispersed chemical compound (4)
 - 2 See? Storm destroyed English county (8)
 - 3 Sailor and gunners with notes in Erode (6)
 - 4 Weakly cries, “New evil spreading in ship” (7)
 - 5 Harbour waves spreading a mist covering star (8)
 - 6 Brown Democrat’s bicycle for two (6)
 - 7 Chopper used protects country (4)
 - 14 US president’s allowance (5)
 - 16 A seat is broken, Confused? (2,3)
 - 18 Mere lads go crazy producing gemstones (8)
 - 20 Boat parts got by warlocks abandoning women and going after Oscar! (8)
 - 21 Student dropping pole from part of 23 in African country (7)
 - 23 Country formed on reconstitution of USSR, with eastern part of Asia (6)
 - 25 Find Line of Control at end of exercise (6)
 - 27 Expel both characters from bathroom mistakenly and wander (4)
 - 29 Sunrise? About time for cashews, macadamias, pecans and the like (4)

SUDOKU



Solution to previous puzzle



Solution to yesterday’s Sudoku



FAITH

Urdhva Tandava explained

One of Lord Siva’s many tandavas (dances) is the urdhva tandava, where His right leg is raised above His head. The story usually given explaining this tandava is that there was once a dance competition between Kali and Siva. Siva raised His right leg above His head, and asked Kali to repeat the move. She said it would be immodest if a woman struck such a pose, and conceded defeat. But this is not the explanation, said Sumathi Sri in a discourse. The story begins with Daksha, father of Dakshayani (Parvati). Dakshayani married Siva. Besides Dakshayani, Daksha had 27 daughters, representing the 27 stars. Chandra fell in love with Rohini. But Daksha requested him to marry all his 27 daughters. Chandra agreed. However, the only wife he loved was Rohini. So, he neglected the other wives. Rohini’s sisters complained to Daksha. The latter cursed Chandra and said he should start waning.

As the moon started waning, he became nervous. So, he approached Lord Siva for help. Siva said He would put Chandra on His head, and Chandra would then start waxing. But what Chandra had done was wrong. Therefore, he would wane, as Daksha had wanted, but would also grow back. And none could harm him, because he was on Siva’s head. Arunagirinatha in a verse talks of the Siva-Kali dance, where he refers to Kali as *abhinna Kali* (the one not separated from Siva). This shows that Siva and Kali did not dance separately. They danced together as Ardhanareeswara. It was while they were dancing as Ardhanareeswara, that the waning Chandra fell at Siva’s feet, seeking help. Siva picked him up with His toes and put him on His head. That was why His right leg was raised during the dance.

DAMASCUS

'Israel strikes Syria airspace hours after visit by Turkish delegation'



REUTERS

A Turkish delegation had visited an airbase in northern Syria the day before it was hit by Israeli air strikes, Syrian officials said. The Israeli strikes hit the Abu Duhur base early Tuesday, hours after the delegation had left, causing damage but no casualties. It was the first confirmation of a Turkish presence at the Abu Duhur base. AP

DHAKA

After a 35-year gap, Bangladesh to vote in presidential election today



AFP

Bangladesh will hold its presidential election on Thursday, with lawmakers set to choose between the ruling BNP stalwart Mirza Fakhrul Islam Alamgir and 11-party Opposition alliance candidate Colonel Oli Ahmed (retired). The voting will take place for the first time in a presidential election after a gap of 35 years. PTI

BANGUI

Toll in mine collapse in Central African Republic rises to over 100



AFP

The death toll from a gold mine collapse in a western part of Central African Republic has risen to more than 100, a Red Cross volunteer involved in relief efforts and a local official said on Wednesday. The low-tech, artisanal gold mine collapsed on Tuesday morning in the village of Zambaye near the border with Cameroon. AP

ISLAMABAD

Pakistan extends airspace ban for Indian aircraft till September 24



REUTERS

Pakistan on Wednesday extended the closure of its airspace to Indian aircraft until September 24. The decision comes ahead of the expiry of the previous restriction on August 23. Pakistan and India imposed matching airspace restrictions on each other's airlines after the Pahalgam terrorist attack in April 2025. PTI

Iran warns Gulf countries against helping U.S. after UAE cuts trade ties

Iran's armed forces warn that helping or facilitating U.S. military operations will amount to participation in war; the UAE announced that it would sever economic ties with Iran after it alleged that Iranian missiles attacked vessels near its coast

Agence France-Presse
TEHRAN

Iran's armed forces warned Gulf countries against assisting the U.S. military on Wednesday, hours after the United Arab Emirates announced it was severing economic ties with Tehran following new attacks on shipping.

The Gulf is dotted with U.S. military installations, including in the UAE, which said on Tuesday that Iran had fired two ballistic missiles at vessels off its coast.

Despite a recent lull in hostilities between the United States and Iran, the Strait of Hormuz — which



War scare: A satellite image shows aircraft at Prince Sultan Air Base in Saudi Arabia. REUTERS

Tehran has blockaded and through which vessels departing most UAE ports must pass — remains a flashpoint, and attacks on commercial ships have

continued. A framework U.S.-Iran deal aimed at reopening the vital trade corridor collapsed, and although both sides recently said messages were being

exchanged, U.S. President Donald Trump on Tuesday insisted talks were off, taunting Iran with a social media post depicting the strait as a "NEW U.S. Territory".

'Participation in war'
Iranian armed forces chief of staff Ali Abdullahi warned on Wednesday "that any assistance or facilitation provided to the aggressor U.S. military amounts to participation in the U.S. military operation", according to the Mehr news agency.

The war between Iran and the United States broke out on February 28 with U.S.-Israeli attacks on

the Islamic republic, which retaliated with missile and drone strikes across the region.

Since the start of the conflict, many West Asian countries have said they would not allow the United States to use their territory as a launchpad for attacks, though Mr. Abdullahi cast doubt on those promises.

"It seems unlikely that such a large number of military aircraft, particularly refueling aircraft, could be present at regional bases without knowledge of host countries," said Mr. Abdullahi, adding Gulf countries "should know that we are fully aware of the situation".

U.S. pauses 50% tariffs on Canadian goods for 3 days

Agence France-Presse
WASHINGTON

U.S. President Donald Trump paused the planned rollout of punishing new tariffs on Canadian goods late on Tuesday, as both sides indicated they were close to a broader trade agreement after weeks of talks.

Mr. Trump announced the three-day reprieve from 50% duties on select goods just hours before a midnight deadline.

The delay was "based on the fact that Canada and the U.S.A., subject to the finalization of documents, have a DEAL!" Mr. Trump wrote on his Truth Social platform.

Canadian Prime Minister Mark Carney was less definitive, saying "substantial progress has been



A file photo of Canada PM Mark Carney and U.S. President Donald Trump at the White House in Washington DC. AP

made" towards a comprehensive trade deal, but "there is important work still to be done".

Ottawa and Washington have held intense negotiations on revising their existing deal, the United States-Canada-Mexico Agreement (USMCA), which Mr. Trump signed and praised during his first

term but now says needs to change.

The U.S. Trade Representative's office said on X that the pact between Washington and Ottawa is set to "include comprehensive market access for all American goods, economic security commitments, digital trade alignment" and other provisions.

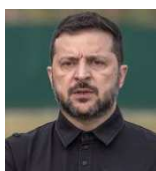
Russian drone strikes kill at least five in Ukraine's Kherson

Reuters
KYIV

A Russian drone strike on a minibus in Ukraine's southern city of Kherson killed four persons on Wednesday, Ukrainian authorities said, in what President Volodymyr Zelenskyy described as a "vicious" attack.

Another woman was killed and a man wounded in a separate drone attack on a car in the central part of the city, the governor of the surrounding region, Oleksandr Prokudin, said on the Telegram messaging app.

The four passengers — a man and three women — were killed in a morning at-



Volodymyr Zelenskyy

tack on the minibus, Mr. Prokudin added.

There was no immediate comment from Russia on the incidents.

"The vicious Russian 'safari' against our people in Kherson has long gone beyond anything a normal person could imagine," Mr. Zelenskyy said on X.

China recovers first stage of a rocket on land for the first time

Associated Press
BEIJING

China has successfully recovered the first stage of a rocket on land for the first time, state media reported on Wednesday, as the country seeks to advance its space programme.

Although this marks China's first successful recovery on land, it is the second time the country has recovered a rocket stage, following a successful recovery on a sea platform in July.

Chinese state news agency Xinhua said the reusable rocket, Zhuque-3, was launched on Wednesday morning and that the rocket's first stage was re-

covered afterward.

Elon Musk's SpaceX and Jeff Bezos's Blue Origin have been recovering rockets since 2015, helping drive down launch costs by reusing hardware that would otherwise be discarded after carrying satellites and other payloads toward space.

Xinhua said that Wednesday's recovery also marked China's first use of deployable landing legs and deemed the result "a major breakthrough in the country's reusable rocket technology".

On July 10, the first stage of a Long March-10B rocket separated from the second stage after lift-off and returned to a platform at sea.

India to build hospital in West Bank; seeks to deploy field hospital in Gaza

Kallol Bhattacharjee
NEW DELHI

India has reiterated its developmental and health-related commitments to the state of Palestine and emphasised the need for a 'two-state solution' to the Israel-Palestinian conflict. India's message was conveyed during the ongoing visit of Secretary of the Ministry of External Affairs, Sripriya Ranganathan, to Ramallah, the administrative headquarters of the Palestinian Authority (PA).

Ms. Ranganathan, the highest-ranking Indian diplomat to visit the West Bank since Hamas's October 7, 2023 attack, discussed a range of Indian initiatives with Palestinian officials,

including the deployment of an Indian field hospital in Gaza Strip, said the Indian Representative Office in Palestine. On Wednesday, the Indian and Palestinian teams launched the construction work of a super-specialty hospital in Jenin, West Bank.

"She highlighted India's expanding support to the Palestinian health sector, including essential medicines, and anti-cancer drugs, an Artificial Limb Fitting Camp, and the deployment of an Indian field hospital in Gaza. During the engagement, the Secretary also handed over a consignment of medicines from the Government of India to the Palestinian Ministry of Health, reaffirm-



Sripriya Ranganathan

ing India's continued support to Palestinian healthcare services," the Indian mission in Ramallah said in a statement.

Ms. Ranganathan met Dr. Majed Abu Ramadan, the Minister of Health of the State of Palestine and Dr. Varsen Aghebekian Shahin, the Minister of Foreign Affairs, and reiterated

ed India's support for a "two-state solution" and pitched for addressing the "humanitarian situation in Gaza". Ms. Ranganathan called on Dr. Mohammad Mustafa, Prime Minister of Palestine on Wednesday. "Discussions focused on further strengthening the longstanding India-Palestine partnership and advancing bilateral cooperation across key areas of mutual interest," the Indian mission said.

On Wednesday, the Indian and Palestinian teams jointly carried out the groundbreaking ceremony for the 200-seat super-specialty hospital that will be built in the Arrabeh city in Jenin Governorate in northern West Bank.

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YOUNG GUN FIRES

Rahul lauds Suthar's subtle variations and consistency



PTI

Left-arm spinner Manav Suthar's 10-wicket haul was a key factor in India's triumph over Sri Lanka in the first Test. His performance drew praise from K.L. Rahul. "The subtle variations from the same action, the same angle, the drift and his consistency meant that all modes of dismissal are possible: bowled, caught behind or lbw."

SILVER-LINING

Dinusha handled the pressure exceptionally well: Kirsten



ANI

In a losing cause, Sri Lanka gained one positive as the young Sonal Dinusha flourished. "There's a big step between First Class and International cricket. It's basically pressure and Sonal handled it exceptionally well. He has mental strength, courage and resilience, and is a good example for others," said Lanka coach Gary Kirsten.

CELEBRATION TIME

India marks landmark 600th Test with its 187th victory



AP

India, which played its 600th Test at Galle, has now registered victories in its 300th, 400th, 500th and 600th Tests. With 187 wins, it has joined West Indies for the most wins after Australia (426), England (405), South Africa (191). India has also suffered 188 losses, drawn 244 matches and tied one game (against Australia in 1986).

ROARING START

Suthar does not take long to make a mark in the longest format



ANI

Manav Suthar has taken the second least number of Tests to record a 10-wicket match haul, behind only Narendra Hirwani, who achieved it in his maiden game in January 1988. The 24-year-old is only the fifth Indian to have multiple five-wicket hauls — two in his case — at the completion of two matches.

Suthar the star as India revives its WTC campaign

The tweaker comes to the fore on the final day to finish with a 10-wicket haul as the visiting team goes 1-0 up in the series; Sri Lanka batters capitulate after resistance from Dhananjaya and Dinusha



Spinning a web: Suthar teased and tormented the Sri Lanka batters. PTI

INDIA IN SRI LANKA

K.C. Vijaya Kumar
GALLE

Fringed by a Dutch fort steeped in permanence and an Indian Ocean frothing at the edges, the Galle International Stadium is always a thing of beauty and a joy forever. In this sublime theatre of aesthetics, Shubman Gill's men found their happy space as India defeated Sri Lanka by 165 runs in the first Test that concluded here on Wednesday afternoon.

Trailing by 371 runs, and with hopes of an impossible chase eroding, the host was bowled out for 206 in the second innings, leaving India with a 1-0 lead in the two-Test series. The cricket bandwagon will now move to Colombo for the second Test commencing there on August 23.

The weather remained clear through the concluding day's play in which left-arm spinner Manav Suthar (six for 55) prospered. His three-wicket strike in one over, snuffed out the Sri Lankan resistance. Sonal Dinusha (84), who until then had played with poise, nibbled one down the leg-side and found Dhruv Jurel at leg-slip.

Immediately, Prabath Jayasuriya was bowled as the ball curled past his bat and disturbed the stumps. Lahiru Kumara resisted the hat-trick ball but edged the last delivery of the same over and Rishabh Pant grabbed the catch. Eventually, Keshara Nuwantha,



Breaking through: Jadeja is over the moon after dismissing skipper Dhananjaya. PTI

SCOREBOARD

INDIA — 1ST INNINGS
462 in 116.4 overs.

SRI LANKA — 1ST INNINGS
284 in 79.4 overs.

INDIA — 2ND INNINGS
193 in 48.5 overs.

SRI LANKA — 2ND INNINGS
Target: 372

Nishan Fernando c Prasad b Siraj 6 (27b), Lahiru Udara c Jurel b Suthar 16 (58b, 1v4), Pasindu Sooriyabandara (concussion substitute for Chandimal) lbw b Suthar 0 (1b), Kamindu Mendis c Rahul b Prasad 2 (12b), Dhananjaya de Silva c Suthar b Jadeja 59 (115b, 7v4), Sonal Dinusha c Jurel b Suthar 84 (128b, 8v4, 1v6), Niroshan Dickwella c Pant b Prasad 10 (17b, 1v4), Keshara Nuwantha b Suthar 20 (69b, 2v4), Prabath Jayasuriya b Suthar 0 (1b), Lahiru

Kumara c Pant b Suthar 0 (4b), Asitha Fernando (not out) 0 (1b), Extras (b-5, lb-1, nb-3); 9; Total (in 77.4 overs): 206.

FALL OF WICKETS
1-13 (Nishan, 6.6 overs), 2-14 (Sooriyabandara, 7.2), 3-21 (Kamindu, 10.4), 4-47 (Udara, 21.4), 5-142 (Dhananjaya, 55.2), 6-156 (Dickwella, 59.6), 7-199 (Dinusha, 75.1), 8-199 (Prabath, 75.2), 9-199 (Kumara, 75.6).

INDIA BOWLING
Siraj 9-2-15-1, Suthar 23.4-2-55-6, Prasad 10-3-16-2, Jadeja 23-3-71-1, Kuldeep 11-0-38-0, Padikkal 1-0-5-0.

India won by 165 runs to lead the two-match series 1-0.

Player-of-the-Match: Padikkal.
Second Test: August 23 to 27, Colombo (SSC).

who kept the visitors at bay for a while, became Suthar's last victim as his citadel got rattled and Gill's men became an exultant lot.

Just as the presentation function was about to commence, a sudden burst of rain forced players and organisers to seek the dry confines of the pavilion. A few minutes later, the sun emerged again to reiterate

Galle's whimsical interactions with nature.

Earlier in the morning, resuming at the overnight 84 for four, Sri Lanka found sustenance and hope through skipper Dhananjaya de Silva and Dinusha. The duo offered a mix of classic stonewalling and the odd shot as a dogged partnership took shape. Initially, Gill used Ravindra Jadeja and Mo-

ammed Siraj in a mix of spin and pace.

The Indian skipper kept a clutch of fielders directly under Dhananjaya's gaze, trying to cramp the batter. Dhananjaya square-drove Jadeja for four, survived two lbw appeals, and then cut one past the ropes to get to his 50. Not to be left behind, southpaw Dinusha struck a six off Kuldeep Yadav and reached his 50.

Just as a barren first session seemed India's fate, Dhananjaya (59) top-edged a sweep off Jadeja and the ball descended towards Suthar at short fine-leg. The fifth-wicket 95-run alliance ended and once this breach was effected, the Indians gained their voice.

Next, man Niroshan Dickwella attempted a few reverse-sweeps but when seamer Prasad Krishna pitched it short and angled across, the batter awkwardly slashed and fatally edged.

Sri Lanka moved to 175 for six at lunch, downed for the count with India fancying its chances. The expectation became a reality soon in the afternoon, just 36 minutes after the break.

Our top-order batting cost us the game, says Kirsten

K.C. Vijaya Kumar
GALLE

Gary Kirsten has come a long way. From being the Indian coach under whom M.S. Dhoni's men won the 2011 World Cup at Sri Lanka's expense, to now being the guiding force for the men from the Emerald Isle, Kirsten has traversed diverse paths. Sri Lanka's coach drew heart from the manner in which his wards stretched the first Test.

"From being 90 for five on the third day and to take the Test into the fifth day was pleasing. There was a bit of fight and we were keen to stay in the Test. I was pleased with the attitude of the team but the way we batted, especially our top order, probably cost us the match," summed up Kirsten while talking to the media on Wednesday.

From the rival corner, Kirsten praised Devdutt Padikkal and Manav Suthar: "Padikkal played one of the better Test match innings that I have seen. He did not play too aggressively, just played within himself and batted for a long period. It was a good lesson for other batters. Manav has fantastic talent and he is a great spinner in Tests."

Kirsten also termed the pitch as a "good one".

Padikkal's knock set up the win: Rahul

K.C. Vijaya Kumar
GALLE

Diversity is innate to K.L. Rahul. For someone who can speak Kannada, Tulu, Hindi and English with equal felicity, the switch between cricket's different formats or the fact that he is a link between the eras of Virat Kohli and Shubman Gill, comes easy.

Trying to downplay his mentor's role within the Indian unit, the vice-captain said: "It's everybody's responsibility to help your fellow teammates and the dressing room here is always open. There is no ego here, and there is no shame in asking questions."

Reacting to India's victory over Sri Lanka in the first Test, Rahul told the media: "We ticked most of the boxes and this will give us confidence going into the next game. We also have a big home series (against Australia) coming up next year. So just understanding batting against spin in spinning conditions

is something that we have been working on."

Enthusied by the performance of his Karnataka teammate Devdutt Padikkal, Rahul said: "The way he batted, the tempo that he batted with and to go on and get a big hundred in the first innings really set up the game for us. The conditions were really hot and challenging."

"For him to get through that, get a hundred, make it big and stitch partnerships, that set up this Test for us. He is someone I have played a lot of cricket with."

About Manav Suthar, Rahul added: "He is very consistent and, hopefully, he will keep getting better."

And referencing his own career, Rahul revealed that he had a certain awareness about his game: "I carry calmness into every Test. Having played 60-odd Tests, there is a sense of balance and calmness now when I walk into a Test."

In a relatively young unit, Rahul's zen-state is a bonus.



Showing the way: Rahul was all praise for Padikkal's batting, the tempo at which he made runs and his temperament. PTI

Padikkal and Suthar provide hope for the future with stellar display

K.C. Vijaya Kumar
GALLE

The charge of the young brigade helped India defeat Sri Lanka in the first Test. Devdutt Padikkal, 26, and Manav Suthar, 24, were the prime architects of this demographic bonus rippling with vitality.

Playing his third Test, Padikkal was expected to be both adhesive and aggressive at No. 3, besides living up to the legacy of the Karnataka school of batsmanship with its patrons being G.R. Viswanath and Rahul Dravid. His 167 in the first innings ensured that India never had to look back in this match.

He was decisive in his shot-selection, there was a fluidity to his run accumulation and it also helped that Statemate K.L. Rahul was with him. When the two spoke about each other, both mentioned about understanding the other's tempo at the crease.



Fresh energy: Padikkal grabbed the chance with both hands while Suthar outshone his senior spin colleagues. AP, ANI

Southpaw Padikkal found a berth due to an injury side-lining Sai Sudharshan, but he grabbed his chance on a slow pitch while the weather remained hot and sultry despite the odd shower. Padikkal also registered a 44 in

the second innings, vital runs when India hustled for a bigger lead.

If Padikkal laid the base, Suthar ensured that India's dreams did not vanish. A classical left-arm spinner with loop and drift, Suthar is a throwback to a gentler

past. He can constrict the batters to their crease and also tease them to their doom. His four for 76 and six for 55 were the twin blows from which Sri Lanka never recovered.

Indelible mark

Playing his second Test, Suthar belied no nerves. Among left-arm twirlers in the XI, one that had both Ravindra Jadeja and Kuldeep Yadav, Suthar left an indelible mark. That he can bat a bit is an added bonus as the Indian Test outfit these days is saddled with a fragile tail.

With R. Ashwin having retired and Jadeja in his twilight phase, Suthar is perhaps the man to carry forward the great Indian spin tradition. For both Padikkal and Suthar, a tougher scrutiny would be the home Tests against the visiting Australians next year. But for now, there is the second Test at Colombo to deal with.

India passes Pakistan test, moves into the next round

Harmanpreet shows his class yet again with two penalty-corner conversions while Abhishek also nets a brace; Fulton's men stay untroubled barring a spell in the second quarter

HOCKEY WORLD CUP

Aashin Prasad
AMSTELVEEN

It was, at times, too easy for the Indian men even if they weren't at their best.

India reiterated the gulf in class between it and neighbour Pakistan with a 5-3 win, punching its ticket to the World Cup second round at the Wagener Stadion here on Wednesday. India finished second in Pool D with six points, behind England (nine points).

The India-Pakistan encounter was a high-stakes game on paper with expats from the South Asian nations adding vibrant colour and atmosphere to the setting. There was no added spice with both teams continuing their tradition of pre-match high-fives but the mood extended to the game with goals spread around.

Long balls

Pakistan was content playing on the counter with India having to devise ways to break down its defence. There were plenty of long balls but Pakistan was kind enough to afford space inside the circle, which the Harmanpreet Singh-led team capitalised on.



Marksman: Abhishek was on target twice as India registered a 5-3 win over Pakistan. AFP

India's efficiency from penalty corners has been one of its high points this campaign, and Harmanpreet underscored the attribute with two goals from set-pieces.

A powerful drag-push to the right corner opened India's account in the fourth minute. In open play, Abhishek Nain threatened from the left with his close control and dribbling, scoring twice after his shots found kind deflections into the net.

India was cruising except for the second quarter

when a drop in intensity and misplaced passes resulted in Pakistan's revival. Suraj Karkera's slow reflexes after his initial save allowed Shahid Hannan to push home the rebound.

Both sides exchanged blows from PCs. Harmanpreet netted his fifth goal of the tournament before Sufyan Khan scored from a deflection off the first rusher.

India extended its advantage in the third quarter after Hardik Singh converted a penalty stroke, but the midfielder's cheap

giveaway put Hannan through on goal for Pakistan's third.

Pakistan tried to push hard in the final minutes when it earned a PC but failed with its execution, giving India breathing space. While Craig Fulton men's have ticked off the first target, things will only get harder from here on. But does this Indian team have more to offer?

The result: Pakistan 3 (Hannan 21, 45, Sufyan 24-pc) lost to India 5 (Harmanpreet 4-pc, 20-pc, Abhishek 10, 23, Hardik 34-pc).

Ayush, Sindhu have it easy; lacklustre Lakshya suffers a shock defeat

BADMINTON WORLDS

Uthra Ganesan
NEW DELHI

When Garret Tan took a medical timeout leading 17-16 in the decider, it looked like Lakshya Sen would finally get the stroke of luck he so desperately needed.

Instead, the 18-year-old American of Taiwanese descent would jump, smash and punch his way to the biggest win of his career so far. He packed off the home favourite 19-21, 21-19, 21-17 in an hour and 13 minutes in the second round of the badminton World Championships here on Wednesday.

Having scraped through his opening-round match, Lakshya, ranked 14th and a bronze medalist at the global tournament, was expected to have an easy outing against the World No. 92 Tan.

Disappointment

But, on a day Ayush Shetty had an easier time than in his sparring sessions and P.V. Sindhu broke little sweat to reach the pre-quarterfinals, Lakshya floundered against an opponent who did not allow him any space or momentum.

The contest was as much in the mind as on the court. Tan, a former Junior World No. 1, packed power in his overhead and cross-court smashes that often left Lakshya stranded in the middle. He was equally



Smooth sailing: Sindhu broke no sweat during her victory over Zhang. SHIV KUMAR PUSHPAKAR

impressive with his drops but the Indian managed to edge ahead by taking the opening game.

Leading 11-8 in the second game, Tan capitalised on his opponent's mistakes at the net with high lifts to the back of the court. Every time Lakshya looked to get a foothold, his rival unleashed smash-winning winners.

Tan raced to a 11-4 advantage in the decider and it looked all over for Lakshya before the Indian rode on crowd support to come within striking distance.

But the American's timeout followed by a series of jump smashes ended hopes.

Ayush, meanwhile, wrapped up his match against Sri Lanka's Dumindu Abeywickrama 21-8, 21-10 in 25 minutes and Sind-

hu took 10 more minutes to beat Canadian Wen Yu Zhang 21-16, 21-17 to set up a clash with Wang Zhiyi (China). Unnati Hooda, however, went down fighting 21-11, 9-21, 21-23 to 13th seed Michelle Li of Canada.

Bringing cheer

In doubles, Dhruv Kapila and Tanisha Crasto advanced with a 21-11, 21-11 win against Lok Chong Leong and Weng Chi Ng of Macau. Satwiksairaj Rankireddy and Chirag Shetty rode out a walkover after the Scottish pair of Alexander Dunn and Adam Pringle withdrew following Dunn's injury.

Important results:

Men: Loh Kean Yew (Sin) bt Cheuk Yu Lee (Hkg) 15-21, 21-17, 21-15; Chou Tien Chen (Tpe) bt Giovanni Toti (Ita) 21-12, 21-11; Jonatan Christie (Ind) bt Jia Heng

Tef (Sin) 19-21, 21-19, 21-11; Rasmus Gemke (Den) bt Chun-Yi Lin (Tpe) 13-21, 21-17, 21-11; Li Shifeng (Chn) bt Jun Hao Leong (Mas) 21-19, 21-19; Garret Tan (USA) bt Lakshya Sen 19-21, 21-19, 21-17; Ayush Shetty bt Dumindu Abeywickrama (SL) 21-8, 21-10. **Doubles:** Fajar Alfian & Muhammad Shohibul Fikri (Ind) bt Eloi Adam & Leo Rossi (Fra) 21-14, 21-13; Kang Min Hyuk & Ki Dong Ju (Kor) bt Hariharan Ansaikumar & M.R. Arjun 21-17, 21-14; Satwiksairaj Rankireddy & Chirag Shetty w/o Alexander Dunn & Adam Pringle (Sco). **Women:** An Se-yung (Kor) bt Thalita Ramadani Wiryawan (Ind) 21-15, 21-11; Michelle Li (Can) bt Unnati Hooda 11-21, 21-9, 23-21; P.V. Sindhu bt Wen Yu Zhang (Can) 21-16, 21-17. **Doubles:** Peary Tan & Thinaah Muralitharan (Mas) bt Bengisu Ercetin & Nadiac Inci (Tur) 21-16, 21-13. **Mixed doubles:** Dhruv Kapila & Tanisha Crasto bt Lok Chong Leong & Weng Chi Ng (Mac) 21-11, 21-11.

Chennai to host Duleep Trophy final

Sports Bureau
CHENNAI

Chennai's M.A. Chidambaram Stadium will host the final of the Duleep Trophy from September 6 to 10.

The BCCI has decided to move the summit clash from Bengaluru to allow fans a chance to watch the country's top players in action.

While the initial plan was to hold the entire tournament at the BCCI's Centre of Excellence (CoE) in the Garden City, only the quarterfinal and semifinals will now be held on campus.

Earlier this month, BCCI secretary Devajit Saikia had explained that there were restrictions on allowing fans at the CoE but had promised to consider hosting the final alone in a proper stadium.

"The Duleep Trophy is an important first-class tournament in our calendar and carries a rich legacy. The quality of cricket is always high, and we want fans to have the opportunity to watch the final live at the stadium. There are certain restrictions regarding crowd attendance at the CoE, and we felt it was appropriate to move the final to a venue where fans can attend and be part of the occasion. We have also increased coverage of the tournament and all matches of the Duleep Trophy will be streamed live, and there will also be TV coverage of one quarter-final, one semi-final and the final," said Saikia.

The two quarterfinals will be played from August 23 to 26, with East Zone taking on North-East while North and West facing off in the other encounter.

The winners will take on last year's winner Central Zone and runner-up South Zone respectively in the semifinals to be held from Aug. 30 to Sept. 2.

Robinson, Tongue combine to bundle out Pakistan for 171



Robinson. AFP

Agence France-Presse
LONDON

Ollie Robinson became the first man to take a wicket with the first ball of a Test series in England as the recalled seamer gave the hosts the advantage on the first day against Pakistan at Headingley on Wednesday.

Pakistan was bundled out for 171 in 48.1 overs (Robinson 42, Abdullah Shafique 61, Robinson 5/51, Tongue 5/46) vs England 112/2 in 25 overs. **Toss:** England.

The home team ended the day at 112 for two with Jordan Cox (23 batting) and

skipper Joe Root (37 batting) at the crease. The openers - Ben Duckett (15) and Emilio Gay (33) - were the batters to be dismissed.

At tea, Pakistan was 150 for seven in tea on the opening day of a three-match series in England's first Test of the post-Bazball era.

Tongue struck after tea by picking dismissing Mohammed Rizwan (12) and Mohammed Abbas (2) while Robinson got Khuram Shahzad (14).

The scores: Pakistan 171 in 48.1 overs (Imam-ul-Haq 42, Abdullah Shafique 61, Robinson 5/51, Tongue 5/46) vs England 112/2 in 25 overs. **Toss:** England.

F1 won't happen before 2029, but pushing for WRC: Arindam

S. Dipak Ragav
CHENNAI

Even as there is a renewed push to bring Formula One back to India, FMSCI president Arindam Ghosh said the federation is also pursuing opportunities to bring the World Rally Championship (WRC) to the country.

"F1 won't happen before 2029, but I am pushing for WRC before that. You don't need huge infrastructure for that. What we need is road sanitisation and government administration support. The government is supportive of it," said Arindam on the sidelines of the launch of the Chennai Turbo Riders-JK Tyre FMSCI Indian National Car Racing Championship 2026 here on Wednesday.

"I won't be shocked if, instead of BIC, we are having a street circuit as we don't have a maintenance issue right through the year," he added.

The logo of the new National championship was



At the launch: Arindam Ghosh, Akbar Ebrahim, A. Srinath and other dignitaries. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

launched by A. Srinath, Minister of Fisheries & Fisheries Welfare, Govt. of TN.

"I would like to express my gratitude to CTR and JK Tyre for their support and commitment to promoting motorsport in the country, and creating a road safety awareness," said Srinath. Akbar Ebrahim, Member, FIA World Motor Sport Council and President, FIA International Karting Commission, said: "Indian motorsport is being keenly viewed and watched by the FIA as it is a very important country at the global level."

The first two rounds of the four-round season will be held at the Kar Motor Speedway in Coimbatore (Sept. 11-13 and Oct. 23-25).

The third round will be run at BREN Raceway in Bengaluru (Nov. 13-15) while the final round will be at the Madras International Circuit (Dec. 11-13).

There will be seven categories in the National championship: Indian Super Touring Cars, Indian Junior Touring Cars, Super Stock, Levitas Cup, Formula LGB F4 and Formula 1300.



Lakshya and Tan. SHIV KUMAR PUSHPAKAR

I was playing catch-up, says Lakshya

Uthra Ganesan
NEW DELHI

For once, Lakshya Sen didn't have an answer to his opponent's game, on or off the court.

Garret Tan dominated the second-round match against the Indian World No. 14 and Lakshya admitted there was little he could do.

"It was a good match, lot of credit to Tan, he played a solid game. Towards the end of the third game, both of us were completely exhausted. I gave my all but it wasn't enough and I am a little disappointed," Lakshya admitted.

"He was dominant throughout and I was constantly playing cover-up with the points. I had my chances but was always under pressure. Both his attack and defence were solid," he added.

Garret, meanwhile, was still trying to recover from an on-court medical concern and the biggest win of his career.

"I went for a slide and hit my head a little bit and wasn't feeling very well. I am speechless right now. I just wanted to go and play my best without thinking of who was in front of me," the 18-year-old said.

Asked where the game changed, Garret's response revealed he had done his homework. "In the last few points, I just changed direction and it worked. I was supposed to leave on Friday, but I guess..." he laughed as the words left unsaid spoke a lot.

Plenty of positives for Unnati despite loss to Li

Devyanshi Bihani
NEW DELHI

Unnati Hooda's World Championships debut ended in a three-game defeat (21-11, 19-21, 21-23) to 13th seed Michelle Li in the second round on Wednesday. She took the opening game comfortably, but the deciding game went down to the wire, with Unnati admitting that a handful of errors proved costly.

"I feel like in between two or three points, I made a few silly mistakes that shouldn't have been made," the Indian said. "Because she's World No. 13, I think that's why the silly mistakes [from Michelle] were very few in the critical moments. And whenever she had the chance, she just took it. I have to learn this from playing against the higher-ranked players," she added.

The Canadian, was equally appreciative of the fight the 18-year-old brought to the contest.

"She's very talented, lots of potential. I think



Big fight: Unnati pushed World No. 13 Li to the limit before succumbing. SHIV KUMAR PUSHPAKAR

she's very quick on her feet, and she's got great shots and she's a fighter. Today she played really well...I had to grind pretty hard to pull out the win," she said.

For Unnati, the match also offered plenty of positives.

"I controlled well with the dribble, I adjusted well and... my net game has really improved from my past," she said. She also felt that she "was a bit more patient" than in her previous games, sticking to her plan and changing it

when the Canadian adapted. In the final game, she forgot "for one second that there is a drift on that [near] side of the court," while she considered a flick serve at one stage but eventually chose against it because she felt both of their "smashes were going really good."

For a teenager making her Worlds debut, the defeat was a painful one. However, Unnati was richer by the experience and the knowledge of the fine margins required at the top level.

East Bengal sneaks into the final

DURAND CUP

Amitabha Das Sharma
KOLKATA

East Bengal FC reached the final of the 135th Durand Cup after defeating Sporting Club Delhi 5-3 on penalties in the first semifinal here on Wednesday.

The match remained goalless in regulation time, with East Bengal dominating the attacking third but failing to convert the chances. As tournament regulations do not provide for extra-time, the match went to penalty shootout.

East Bengal converted

all five attempts in the shootout, while goalkeeper Prabhukhan Singh Gid produced the decisive moment by saving SC Delhi's first attempt from Juan Sebastian Pena.

That gave East Bengal the advantage, which it maintained to secure a 5-3 victory.

East Bengal had several opportunities during the match. In the third minute, Edmund Lalrindika's clever back-heel sent Jesin into the box, but Bipin narrowly missed with his cross.

Basim Rashid then rattled the crossbar with a free-kick in the 16th minute before Jesin T.K. struck the

right post three minutes later. SC Delhi was awarded a penalty in the 33rd minute after Rodrigoinho was brought down by East Bengal defender Sandip Mandi. Gid, however, stood tall to deny Rodrigoinho from the spot. East Bengal continued to press after the break, but SC Delhi defended resolutely.

The shootout ultimately settled the contest and sent East Bengal into the Durand Cup final for the 28th time.

The result:

Semifinal: East Bengal 0 drew with Sporting Club Delhi 0 (East Bengal won 5-3 on penalties).

communities from govt. schools across the country

to power supply on a priority basis.

site inspection of the Surajpur Industrial Area on Monday. During the inspection, he reviewed the infrastructure facilities available in the industrial area, the ongoing and proposed infrastructure development works, and the arrangements related to the smooth functioning of industrial units. The Chief Executive Officer directed the Senior Manager (Civil) to ensure timely completion of road and drain construction as well as other civil works in accordance with prescribed standards and with high quality. At the same time, the Senior Manager (Electrical) was directed to ensure uninterrupted power supply to industrial units and to ensure prompt resolution of issues and complaints related to power supply on a priority basis.

INBRIEF



Rodri joins Barcelona from Manchester City

Barcelona on Tuesday announced the signing of Spain's World Cup-winning captain Rodri from Premier League side Manchester City. The *LaLiga* champion said the 30-year-old has signed a deal till 2030. According to reports on Sunday, Barca and Man City reached a deal to complete the transfer for a fee of around \$87 million. Rodri was a vital figure for Pep Guardiola at City, leading the team to the 2023 Champions League and four PL titles among 12 major trophies.

Tickets for GCL go on sale on BookMyShow

The ticket sales for the fourth edition of Global Chess League, to be held in Bengaluru from September 5 to 13, have opened on BookMyShow. According to a release from the GCL, a joint venture of Tech Mahindra and FIDE, the price of tickets starts at ₹349. The league features some of the biggest names in chess, led by the World No. 1 Magnus Carlsen. "GCL is built to be experienced live, and Bengaluru will give fans a chance to get much closer to the action," said Gourav Rakshit, Commissioner, GCL.

Badoni's blistering knock guides Superstarz home

The flamboyant batter makes a stirring impact with a 47-ball 90 to chase down a target of 208 against Strikers; Doseja's unbeaten half-century is the cornerstone of Lions' win over Tigers

DPL

Sports Bureau
NEW DELHI

Before joining up with the North Zone squad in Bengaluru for the Duleep Trophy starting on August 23, Ayush Badoni made a stirring impact with a 47-ball 90 for South Delhi Superstarz at the Arun Jaitley Stadium here on Wednesday.

The knock was central to Superstarz chasing down a target of 208 against North Delhi Strikers with four wickets in hand and three balls to spare.

Earlier, Strikers, who were asked to set a target, posted 207 for nine in 20 overs, courtesy a sublime opening partnership of 107



Hammering away: Badoni smashed eight sixes during his match-winning effort. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

in 7.2 overs between skipper Sarthak Ranjan and Yash Dabas.

While Sarthak made a 23-ball 45, Dabas smashed 78 off 38 balls. But once the two departed, Superstarz managed to strike regular-

ly. The tall chase was spearheaded by the diminutive Badoni.

Having walked in at No. 3, he walloped four fours and eight maximums during the course of his innings. While Ajay Yadav

took three wickets for Strikers, his economy rate was a costly 12.9 runs per over. Ayush Doseja's unbeaten 64 was the cornerstone of West Delhi Lions' six-wicket win over New Delhi Tigers.

The southpaw's knock helped Lions knock off a target of 196 in 19.2 overs.

The scores: North Delhi Strikers 207/9 in 20 overs (Sarthak Ranjan 45, Yash Dabas 78, Anshuman Hooda 2/55, Ankit Dabas 2/18, Divansh Rawat 3/22) lost to South Delhi Superstarz 208/6 in 19.3 overs (Ayush Badoni 90, Ajay Yadav 3/45).

New Delhi Tigers 195/6 in 20 overs (Himmat Singh 35, Keshav Singh 36, Parth Babi 35 n.o., Manish Sehrawat 30 n.o., Mayank Gussain 2/48, Tishant Dabla 2/26) lost to West Delhi Lions 201/4 in 19.2 overs (Rishabh Yadav 45, Nitish Rana 50, Ayush Doseja 64 n.o., Manish Sehrawat 3/20).



Cashing in: Praggnanandhaa made Vachier-Lagrave pay for the risks the Frenchman took. FLICKR/GRANDCHESTOUR

Praggnanandhaa beats Vachier-Lagrave, moves to joint lead

CHESS

Press Trust of India
ST. LOUIS

R. Praggnanandhaa outplayed Maxime Vachier-Lagrave of France to jump to joint lead alongside American Wesley So after the end of the eighth and penultimate round of the Sinquefeld Cup here on Tuesday.

The victory took Praggnanandhaa to five points and the Indian is now assured of a place in the Grand finale scheduled later this year.

On a day when So played another draw with compatriot Samuel Sevian, Javokhir Sindarov won his third game on the trot to be within striking distance of the leaders on 4.5 points. On the receiving end was Jorden Van Foreest of Holland who continues to trail the field.

In another big result of the day, German Vincent Keymer put it across top seed Fabiano Caruana of the United States to join Sindarov in third spot. In other game of the day, Dutchman Anish Giri drew

with Levon Aronian of the United States.

Being his last white game, Maxime Vachier-Lagrave took all the risks against Praggnanandhaa but the tactic boomeranged. The Ruy Lopez was met with another Moller variation by Pragg and an early piece sacrifice by the Frenchman was only optically good.

Praggnanandhaa lost three pawns in exchange for the piece but relocated his forces well to win in just 28 moves.

The results (eighth round):

Sinquefeld Cup: Javokhir Sindarov (Uzb) 4.5 bt Jorden Van Foreest (Ned) 1.5; Samuel Sevian (USA) 4 drew with Wesley So (USA) 5; Vincent Keymer (Ger) 4.5 bt Fabiano Caruana (USA) 4; Anish Giri (Ned) 3.5 drew with Levon Aronian (USA) 3.5; Maxime Vachier-Lagrave (Fra) 4 lost to R. Praggnanandhaa (Ind) 5.

Cairns Cup: Koneru Humpy 3 drew with Diya Deshmukh 4; Tan Zhongyi (Chn) 6.5 bt Bibisara Assaubayeva (Kaz) 4.5; Carissa Yip (USA) 4.5 bt Stavroula Tsolakidou (Gre) 3.5; Anna Muzychuk (Ukr) 4 drew with Alexandra Kosteniuk (Ukr) 2; R. Vaishali 2.5 lost to Alice Lee (USA) 5.5.

Marijne taps into Indian folklore to instil unity

HOCKEY WORLD CUP

Aashin Prasad
AMSTELVEEN

India head coach Sjoerd Marijne and Co. had made their way out onto the turf 30 minutes before the side's Pool-D game against South Africa in the women's World Cup 2026.

While the preparations were going to plan, Marijne appeared to have missed something. He quickly went back to the dugout and held out his right arm

to one of his support staff, who promptly tied a red-and-yellow-coloured band around his wrist.

But it wasn't just unique to Marijne. Every player and support staff, who have travelled to the Netherlands, were also sporting one. It was done at the Dutchman's insistence, with the team calling it the 'unity' band.

Reappointed in February this year, Marijne, who had previously spent four years with the women's band, has been trying to

find ways to restore the belief and confidence back into the group.

Ahead of the World Cup, Marijne has seemingly tried to tap into Indian folklore in his attempt to further solidify their bond.

"I gave it to the girls because I have seen many people wear this; it's a symbol of unity in India," the 52-year-old told *Sportstar*. "Every time they see the band, it should remind them what it means to be a team; focussing on working and being disciplined."



The red-and-yellow-coloured thread sported by the Indian squad. AASHIN PRASAD

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I will try to win the Asian Games gold

Believes the Asian Games would be tougher than the Commonwealth Games and is up for the challenge; says the process of reducing from 54 to 51 kg was difficult but is happy that the move paid rich dividends

INTERVIEW

Sakshi Chaudhary

Y.B. Sarangi

Hailing from Haryana's boxing nursery Bhiwani, Army havildar Sakshi Chaudhary, a former World junior and youth champion, took a tough decision to drop from 54kg to 51kg to find a slot in the 2026 Commonwealth Games-bound Indian team. The gamble paid off as she showed her big heart and came through with flying colours.

After breaking English boxer Ruby White's unbeaten run of 68 bouts and securing a unanimous decision in the women's 51kg final in Glasgow, Sakshi flashed one of the brightest smiles.

Amid attending felicitation functions and getting ready to rejoin the National camp to prepare for the upcoming Asian Games, she spoke to *The Hindu*. Excerpts:

Why did you choose to go down from 54kg to 51kg?

Preeti (Pawar) had won the gold medal in the Asian Championships in 54kg. So there were no trials in that category as she had already qualified for the Commonwealth Games and the Asian Games. I had the option of going to 51kg and going through the trials.

But there was a risk that you might lose because there was a lot of competition. You could have also got injured while cutting down weight.

I did not think of that. I had an option. I was very hungry. No matter what I had to do, I wanted to compete. This was my first experience of competing in 51kg. Before this, I had competed in 50kg at the National Games in 2023.

Since World champions Minakshi Hooda and Nikhat Zareen were the main boxers in 51kg, what was your mindset?

I had decided that I would not worry about whom I faced in the ring. I just had to give my best. I was my own competitor.

How did you adapt in such a short time?

I managed my weight within 20-25 days. I had almost stopped eating. I used to drink very little water. I had to do extra training.

After training, I had to wear a hot suit to lose weight. Besides that, I had to maintain my performance. It was very difficult. When I was at home, my pa-



rents could not see that I was hungry. They used to give me food. I used to ask them not to give me food.

How much did you work on your endurance?

Endurance is my strong point. I am the best in endurance and running in the camp. We also train very hard in the Army. I did not have to work much on endurance and strength.

Which was the most difficult bout in the Commonwealth Games?

The final bout was with Ruby White, the England boxer. Before the final, she had not lost a single bout in her life. She was always winning. I stuck to my strategy to win my first medal in a multi-sport event.

What was your best moment in the Commonwealth Games?

My best moment was when I won the medal. Our National anthem was played as I stood on top of the podium. Earlier, it happened with me in different championships. But the vibes were different at the Games.

How is the training environment in the camp?

The training environment is very good. Mentally, we are free. Technically, we are very good. The coaching staff show us videos

of different bouts. It is not only the athlete who boxes in the ring. There are support staff, including coaches, physios, and psychologists. Our nutritionist used to give us a diet chart of what to eat and what was available there. So everyone has a hand in the success.

There was a small phase when there was a lot of confusion surrounding the selection trials. Did that affect the boxers' minds?

Yes, we needed to stay focused, but the stress had increased a little bit because we did not know whether the trials were happening and when they were happening. We had to manage our weight. There was uncertainty.

What does this Commonwealth Games medal mean to you and how much confidence does it give you?

This is the biggest achievement for me till date, so it means a lot to me. It was for me, for my whole family. They were waiting for so long. I have been boxing for 14 years.

My father and my cousin brother Vinit – he always stayed with me at every step and used to motivate me – backed me a lot. I used to get a little demotivated when I didn't get selected or lost somewhere.

But my family always supported me. I will give them all the credit. I have won the medal because of them. They prayed for me, hoped to see me successful but never expressed their feelings. I could see that there was pressure on them too. They deserved to see me win this medal.

Nitu Ghanghas and you are childhood friends, who won World youth titles together. She became a World champion (at the senior level) before suffering injuries. Do you miss her now?

Yes, I was very happy when she won the gold medal at the last Commonwealth Games. This time I have brought it home, so she is also happy with my medal. Had she been in my weight, we would have

fought in the ring, but we would have remained friends.

In 51kg, we had legends like Mary Kom and Nikhat Zareen. They made India famous. Do you think you can take their place?

No one takes anyone's place. Everyone performs and gives her best. So I will also give my best. And I will try my best to make India famous.

Mary *didi* was an icon, and won medals in the World championships and Olympics. Maybe no one will be able to do that in the future.

How different will the Asian Games challenge be and what is your target?

The Asian Games will be more difficult than the Commonwealth Games, because a lot of good competitors will come. But I believe in myself and that I am going through good form. My training is also going well. So I will keep my focus and will try to win a gold medal there too.

What are the chances of improvement in your game now?

I can work a little on the clinch. Because my long-distance game is good. I mean, I play by keeping the opponent away. I get a height advantage. But when the opponent comes close, I have a little difficulty. So we will work on that.

Tell us about your dream of the Olympics.

My ultimate goal is to bring a gold medal for my country in the Olympics. And I am also working for it. From the day I started, I had this dream that I would win a gold medal in the Olympics.



SCIENCE

If solar irrigation is over-drawing groundwater, it's being done wrong

Over the past five years, India's agricultural solar programme, PM-KUSUM, has installed over 2.5 million solar pumps, making them affordable through subsidies; as the govt. prepares PM-KUSUM 2.0, the challenge is to advance the clean energy transition without continuing to over-exploit groundwater

Mohammad Faiz Alam
Alok Sikka

"Solar irrigation will worsen the groundwater crisis." This concern is raised in most discussions about the rapid spread of solar irrigation in India — where heavily subsidised or free electricity has led to unsustainable groundwater abstraction, contributing to falling water tables, depleting aquifers, and growing fiscal burdens on energy utilities.

Thus, with solar irrigation offering almost free power and no incentive to limit pumping, farmers may draw ever more groundwater.

However, there are three gaps in this framing that one should consider. First, the current debate often treats solar irrigation as a single model — typically a farmer operating a standalone solar pump with no incentive to conserve water.

In reality, solar irrigation models come in different shapes and sizes differentiated by design, ownership structure, and pricing incentives, all of which influence groundwater-related outcomes.

Dependence on model

For example, grid-connected solar models that allow farmers to sell surplus solar electricity back to the grid provides incentives for efficient water use. Evidence from Gujarat's Suryashakti Kisan Yojana (SKY) scheme, where approximately 100 agricultural feeders were transitioned to solar energy, shows that solar farmers had significantly slower growth in energy consumption and irrigation application than non-solar farmers, indicating more sustainable water use.

The SKY scheme offered around ₹7 per unit of energy as a feed-in-tariff, creating a meaningful incentive to conserve electricity and export energy. And by exporting energy, farmers earned an average of roughly ₹21,900 annually, effectively transforming them from energy consumers to energy producers.

Similarly, in Bangladesh, in the most common solar model — called the fee-for-service centralised solar model — pump owners have earned revenue by supplying water to multiple farmers within a fixed command area. This model showed that farmers who used solar irrigation did not apply more water than farmers who used diesel for irrigation even though solar irrigation was 20-30% cheaper.

This is because excessive irrigation by one farmer reduced the operator's ability to serve others, making the efficient and equitable use of groundwater for irrigation imperative for businesses looking to become financially sustainable.

So the real question is not whether solar irrigation is inherently good or bad for groundwater but what kind of solar irrigation model is deployed, where, and with what incentives.

Even for standalone off-grid pumps under the Pradhan Mantri Kisan Urja Suraksha evam Uthhan Mahabhiyan (PM-KUSUM), there is evidence that solar pump utilisation — and the extent to which it replaces diesel versus grid electricity use — varies widely with



Solar irrigation models come in different shapes and sizes differentiated by design, ownership structure, and pricing incentives, all of which influence groundwater-related outcomes. GETTY IMAGES/ISTOCKPHOTO

installed capacity, the water table's depth, and years of operating experience.

Diverse outcomes

Second, the current debate treats energy as the only factor determining groundwater outcomes, discounting the impact of local hydrogeology and agriculture. Evidence shows solar irrigation impact on farmers' irrigation behaviour is shaped by local hydrogeology, cropping patterns, marginal returns to irrigation, and soil type, among other factors.

In regions with hard-rock aquifers with limited water storage capacity, and rainfed cropping, where each additional unit of irrigation water yields high marginal benefits, water use changed little between solar and non-solar uses (regardless of the energy source in the latter case). This diversity in outcomes must be central to policy design.

In regions such as Punjab and Haryana, where irrigation is already widespread and dominated by water-intensive crops like rice and wheat, there is little scope to expand irrigated area, making it unlikely that solar irrigation will drive further groundwater over-exploitation.

The key question in such regions is not whether solar threatens groundwater, but whether it can make water, energy, and food systems more sustainable. Replacing subsidised fossil-fuel electricity with grid-connected solar can reduce subsidy costs, lower emissions, and encourage more efficient water and energy use.

On the other hand, Eastern India presents a different picture where irrigation expansion has been constrained more by access to energy than to water. Large areas remain rainfed, with farmers facing high diesel costs and unreliable power for irrigation. In such regions, solar irrigation can meaningfully improve agricultural productivity and climate resilience.

This shows solar irrigation policy, as it

relates to groundwater, should follow a differentiated regional approach, reflected in context-specific deployment of solar irrigation models, paired with stronger groundwater monitoring and adaptive management to catch emerging stress early.

Emissions, subsidy burdens

A third limitation is when solar irrigation is evaluated in a silo, either as a water or energy intervention, when its consequences span water, energy, and food. For example, groundwater irrigation in India is estimated to generate between 45-62 million tonnes of carbon dioxide a year. Agricultural electricity subsidies across States amount to over ₹1 lakh crore a year. Solar irrigation can reduce both emissions and subsidy burdens.

Estimates from Gujarat suggest each grid-connected solar farmer offsets approximately 12.3 tonnes of CO₂ annually through on-farm solar use and electricity exported to the grid while subsidies covered nearly one-fourth of government investments within the first two years. Scaled across India's more than 25 million agricultural pumps, the mitigation and fiscal implications are substantial. Thus, the question we should be asking is not whether solar irrigation will worsen groundwater risks but how best solar irrigation can be deployed to maximise its benefits.

Expanding access

Over the past five years, India's agricultural solar programme, PM-KUSUM, has installed over 2.5 million solar pumps, making them affordable for smallholder farmers through subsidies. As the government prepares PM-KUSUM 2.0, the challenge is to advance the clean energy transition without worsening the country's already over-exploited groundwater. In water-stressed regions, grid-connected solar can be expanded

either through individual pumps or by making entire agricultural feeders go solar. Ideally, both models should reward farmers for saving water while helping energy distribution companies (DISCOMs) transition to clean energy.

However, the current approach of paying farmers to save water by selling surplus electricity to the grid has seen limited uptake. Feeder-level transitions to solar energy has performed better, but in its current form does little to change pumping behaviour. Both models therefore need to be refined.

The individual pump model requires simpler grid connection procedures and attractive buyback prices that reflect the local value of water and crops. DISCOMs should also be incentivised to support it. Feeder-level transition to solar energy, meanwhile, should be paired with water-saving incentives to reduce both water and energy use, not just benefit DISCOMs. These could include support for micro-irrigation and direct cash payments for reduced pumping, similar to Punjab's 'Pani Bachao, Paisa Kamao' and Haryana's 'Mera Pani Meri Virasat' schemes.

That said, where farmers still lack reliable irrigation, the priority is expanding access rather than saving water. Standalone solar pumps should therefore remain the preferred option in areas with limited irrigation, poor grid access, and low groundwater risk. Rather than focusing on individual ownership, greater emphasis should be placed on scaling them through water-user associations, water-selling entrepreneurs, and farmer cooperatives in India's most irrigation-deprived regions.

(Mohammad Faiz Alam is senior regional researcher at International Water Management Institute and Alok Sikka is an emeritus scientist and former country representative — India and Bangladesh at International Water Management Institute.)



A drone view from October 2024 shows fallen trees in a secondary forest in the Amazon, in Para State, Brazil. REUTERS

How a few tree species drive the recovery of Amazon forest

Agence France-Presse

When a destroyed section of the Amazon rainforest begins to recover, nature deploys only a few tree species, which can withstand poor soil conditions, blazing sun, and grow rapidly, a Brazilian study has shown.

Out of thousands of tree species in the Amazon, a small group of 15 to 25 species do most of the work in regenerating forest and storing carbon when farmers and landowners leave, says Fernando Elias, a researcher at the Emilio Goeldi Museum of Para.

"It is fantastic because the forest is resilient. These species give the forest a new chance" after the "complete rupture" with the environment that happens when trees are felled, he says.

"Once you remove a forest, you are not just removing biodiversity, you are not just removing the carbon that is there. You are removing the forest's ability to regulate the climate."

According to data from Brazil's National Institute for Space Research (INPE), an area roughly the size of Spain has been deforested in Brazil in the past four decades.

Mr. Elias was the lead researcher on the study published last month by the peer-reviewed scientific journal *Global Change Biology*, which aimed at understanding secondary forests that emerge in razed areas of the Brazilian Amazon.

The research was conducted as part of the Sustainable Amazon Network — an international effort to study how deforestation and other human activities are changing the world's largest tropical rainforest.

Mr. Elias said these pioneer species "have the capacity for rapid colonisation" to create conditions for the arrival of species that only occur in mature, primary forests, such as shade — essential for most forest species.

Temperatures under the canopy of these core species can be reduced by up to six degrees Celsius, he said.

The pioneer species produce a lot of leaves which fall to the ground, increase organic matter, and lead to "the beginning of forest recovery."

Spanning nine countries, the Amazon's billions of trees store vast amounts of carbon and are a key buffer against global warming.

According to the study, the Amazon has an area of secondary forests the size of Uruguay.

Secondary forests emerge in abandoned pastures, farms that went bust, or when a landowner has a legal requirement to restore land.

Studying how they bounce back is key to understanding how to restore lost forests.

The authors used data from these recovering forests in four regions of eastern Amazonia, representing more than 25,000 trees and palms.

Some had been regenerating for as little as one year, and others up to 60 years. Among the dominant trees were *Cecropia palmata*, with a pale gray trunk and huge hand-shaped leaves, and *Inga alba*, whose long pods contain an edible sweet white pulp.

Palm species like the towering Inaja and the babassu palm, long valued by rural communities for its oil-rich nuts, were also major players in regeneration.

"If we know which species dominate carbon stocks and dominate the functioning of these ecosystems, we can direct restoration efforts toward them in a way that, for example, makes restoration faster," said Mr. Elias.

Under President Luiz Inacio Lula da Silva's administration, deforestation last year plunged to its lowest levels in a decade. He wants to eradicate forest loss by 2030.

THE SCIENCE QUIZ

Changing with the times: how evolution happens

Yasudevan Mukunth

QUESTION 1

Evolution is not always about the survival of the fittest. Sometimes, by chance, some version of a gene can become more or less common, and a corresponding trait may occur more or less often, to the animal's detriment. In such cases, called _____, evolution is not exactly optimising. Fill in the blanks.

QUESTION 2

According to X theory, mitochondria and chloroplasts were once free-living bacteria that were engulfed by a larger cell roughly 1.5-2 billion years ago, and became permanent residents of the cell. Per this theory, this single event may have made complex life possible by allowing cells to have their own power plants. What does X stand for?

QUESTION 3

In 1972, two palaeontologists named

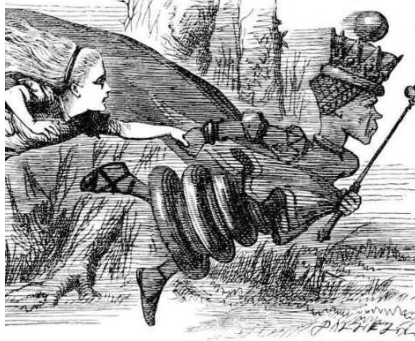
Niles Eldredge and Y proposed that evolution need not always be slow, that species that are evolutionarily stable for long stretches of time can undergo rapid bursts of change on rare occasions, usually due to environmental shocks. Name Y.

QUESTION 4

Some species possess leftover traits that no longer serve their original purpose. Common examples include the human appendix, whale pelvic bones (since they evolved from terrestrial mammals with legs), the wings of ostriches and emus, and the eyes of some cavefish. What are these organs called?

QUESTION 5

Name the evolutionary process that explains why animals sometimes sacrifice themselves for their relatives. The process happens because, since the animal shares its genes with its kin, helping them survive and reproduce can still pass on its genetic material, even if it itself does not reproduce.



Visual: Name the Lewis Carroll character on the right in this 1871 illustration. A hypothesis is named for her that says species have to keep evolving because their predators are evolving, too. PUBLIC DOMAIN

Please send in your answers to
science@thehindu.co.in

Answers to August 13 quiz:

1. Word named for Muhammad ibn Musa al-Khwarizmi — **Ans: Algorithm**
2. Term named for plateau across Slovenia and Italy — **Ans: Kras**
3. Ecology term that comes from the French for 'to make a nest' — **Ans: Niche**
4. Tall ocean wave triggered by undersea earthquakes — **Ans: Tsunami**
5. Subjective sensory world of a specific organism — **Ans: Umwelt**

Visual: **La Niña**

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